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# Bangkok

**Bangkok** (Thai: กรุงเทพมหานคร *Krung Thep*) is the capital and largest city of [Thailand](#). With a population of over eleven million inhabitants, Bangkok is by far Thailand's main city, with the urban sprawl comprising nearly half of Thailand's population, and the largest city on the Southeast Asian mainland. Its high-rise buildings, heavy traffic congestion, intense heat and naughty nightlife do not immediately give you a warm welcome — but don't let your first impression mislead you. It is one of Asia's most cosmopolitan cities with magnificent temples and palaces, authentic canals, busy markets, opulent shopping malls and a vibrant nightlife that has something for everyone.

For years, it was only a small trading post at the banks of the Chao Phraya River, until King Rama I, the first monarch of the present Chakri dynasty, turned it into the capital of Siam in 1782, after the burning of [Ayutthaya](#) by Burmese invaders. Since then, Bangkok has turned into a national treasure house and functions as Thailand's spiritual, cultural, political, commercial, educational and diplomatic centre.

## Districts

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Bangkok is a huge and modern city humming with family activities, nightlife and fervor. Administratively, it is split up into 50 districts (เขต *khet*), which are further split into 180 sub-districts (แขวง *khwaeng*), but these are more often used in official business and for addresses. Visitors will find the conceptual division below of the main areas more useful for getting around.

### **Siam Square**

The area around Siam Square, including Ratchaprasong and Phloen Chit Road, is Bangkok's modern commercial core, full of the main glitzy malls and hotels of Bangkok. The Skytrain intersection at Siam Square is the closest thing Bangkok has to a centre.

### **Sukhumvit**

The long Sukhumvit Road is an exclusive district popular among expatriates and wealthy locals. It is filled with quality hotels, restaurants and nightclubs and has the famous BTS Skytrain running along it. Part of its nightlife represents Bangkok's naughty image, particularly Soi Cowboy and Nana Entertainment Plaza.

### **Silom**

The area around Silom Road and Sathorn Road is Thailand's sober financial centre by day, but Bangkok's primary party district by night when quarters like the infamous Patpong come alive. Numerous embassies are located here.

## **Rattanakosin**

Between the river and Sukhumvit lies the densely packed "Old Bangkok", home to Bangkok's best-known sights, such as the Grand Palace and Wat Pho.

## **Khao San Road**

On the northern part of Rattanakosin, Bangkok's backpacker mecca Khao San Road and the surrounding district of Banglamphu have everything a budget traveller could possibly be looking for.

## **Yaowarat and Phahurat**

Along Yaowarat Road you will find Bangkok's Chinatown, while Phahurat Road is one of the numerous areas of the city's sizeable Indian community. This multicultural district is filled with temples, shrines, seafood restaurants and street markets.

## **Dusit**

This leafy, European-style area is the political centre of Thailand, home to numerous political institutions and the monarchy. Its breezy palaces, lush gardens and broad avenues give this district its distinct character.

## **Thonburi**

The quieter west bank of the Chao Phraya River. Most visitors explore this district with a canal tour, at least taking in Wat Arun, the Royal Barges National Museum and one of the floating markets.

## **Pratunam**

Pratunam is a large garment market with hundreds of fashion stores selling both retail and wholesale. It also includes a large Indian community, Baiyoke Tower II and Victory Monument.

## **Phahonyothin**

The area around Phahonyothin Road and Viphavadi Rangsit Road is a large suburb in



Map of Central Bangkok — [switch to interactive map](#)

northern Bangkok. In weekends, it is the best place to go hunting for bargains. The Chatuchak Weekend Market has more than 8,000 stalls selling anything and everything under the sun. Nearby is the new main railway station for Bangkok funded by Japan.

### **Ratchadaphisek**

Since the completion of the metro line, Ratchadaphisek Road has developed into an entertainment mecca for the locals. The sois, (side streets off busy main roads of "Ratchada" are popular clubbing spots, as is Royal City Avenue (RCA). Pracha Rat Bamphen in Hwai Khwang is known as Bangkok's "New Chinatown", and accordingly is home to a large number of immigrants and expatriates from China.

### **Ramkhamhaeng**

Along Ramkhamhaeng Road lies a vast residential area with big shopping malls and amusement parks (like Safari World). Each neighbourhood has its own distinct character, but Hua Mak and Bang Kapi stand out as lively areas with many students from the universities.

Around Bangkok are the provinces of Nakhon Pathom to the west, Nonthaburi to the northwest, Pathum Thani to the north, Chachoengsao to the east, Samut Prakan to the southeast and Samut Sakhon to the southwest.

## **Understand**

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Just under 14 degrees north of the equator, Bangkok is a tropical metropolis that is also one of the most traveller-friendly cities in Asia. A furious assault on the senses, visitors from northern climates are immediately confronted by the heat, the pollution, unpleasant smells, and the irrepressible smile worn by many Thais. The city is surprisingly **safe** (except for petty crimes) and more organised than it initially appears, and is full of **hidden gems** waiting to be discovered. The high relative humidity and warm temperature favour the growth of tropical plants — you'll find exotic orchids and delicious fruit everywhere. Bougainvillea and frangipani bloom practically all over the city. Thai cuisine is justifiably famous, varied, and affordable. Bangkok for many represents the quintessential Asian capital. Saffron-robed monks, garish neon signs, graceful Thai architecture, spicy dishes, colourful markets, traffic jams, and the tropical climate come together in a happy coincidence. It is difficult to leave with only lukewarm impressions of the city.

## **History**

"Bangkok" was originally a small village on the west bank of the Chao Phraya River. After the fall of Ayutthaya in the late 18th century, King Taksin the Great turned that village into Siam's new capital and renamed it Thonburi. In 1782, King Rama I moved the capital to the eastern bank of the river at Rattanakosin; originally the site of a Chinese community, which was moved outside the new city walls to Yaowarat. King Rama I named the city *Krung Thep*, as it is now known to Thais, and which in English translates as the "City of Angels".



Chakri Maha Prasat Hall, Grand Palace



The full name "*Krungthepmahanakhon Amonrattanakosin Mahintharayutthaya Mahadilokphop Noppharatchathaniburirom Udomratchaniwetmahasathan Amonphimanawatansathit Sakkathattiyawitsanukamprasit*" (กรุงเทพมหานคร อมรรัตนโกสินทร์ มหินทรายุธยามหาดิลกภพ นพรัตนราชธานี บูรรมย์อุดมราชินเวศน์มหาสฐาน อมรพิमानอวตารสถิต สักกะทัตติยะวิษณุกรรมประสิทธิ์) is listed as the world's longest location name by the Guinness Book of Records; an English rendering goes like this: "The city of angels, the great city, the residence of the Emerald Buddha, the impregnable city of Ayutthaya of God Indra, the grand capital of the world endowed with nine precious gems, the happy city, abounding in an enormous Royal Palace that resembles the heavenly abode where reigns the reincarnated god, a city given by Indra and built by Vishnukarn". Foreigners never caught on to the change, so in foreign languages *Krung Thep* inherited the name Bangkok, which became its formal English name. For Thais, the name Bangkok refers to the former village on the west bank of the Chao Phraya, which was incorporated into Greater Bangkok in 1971.

Life was taking place on the water; ordinary people lived on bamboo-rafts along the river, while floating vendors roamed the water to sell fruit and vegetables. The only stone structures built on land were temples and palaces. In the 19th-century, Western powers incorporated much of Southeast Asia into their colonial empires. Kings Rama IV and V felt that the only way to keep Siam independent was to modernise the country along European lines. Traditional canals were filled up and turned into roads. King Rama V moved the residence of the King to Dusit and laid out that district's grand boulevards along European lines.

Bangkok really started to develop after World War II. The economic centre shifted from the orderly planned city of Rattanakosin in an eastward direction, leaving Bangkok without an obvious centre. Bangkok established itself as the driving power behind Thailand's new role as a newly industrializing country from the 1980s onwards. Rapid economic growth has attracted migration from the countryside, with millions of Thais moving here from Isaan and other regions to make a living. As Thailand has grown into the main economic centre of the region, in modern times, Bangkok has also attracted many migrant workers from neighbouring Myanmar, Laos, and Cambodia.

This rapid expansion turned Bangkok into one of the most cosmopolitan and happening cities in Asia; but also ensured numerous problems. A wide gap has emerged between those who profit from economic activity, and those who came to the city from the countryside in search of work. Bangkok's seemingly never-ending traffic jams continue as the new Skytrain and MRT systems are too expensive for the working class. Getting a break from the fumes in a park would seem to be a good idea, but unfortunately, Bangkok has the lowest amount of green space of all capital cities in the world.

## Addresses and navigation

Addresses in Bangkok use the Thai addressing system, which may be a little confusing to the uninitiated. Large roads such as Silom or Sukhumvit are **thanon** (ถนน), often abbreviated *Th* or glossed "Road", while the side streets branching off from them are called **soi** (ซอย). Sois are numbered, with even numbers on one side and odd numbers on the other side. Thus, an address like "25 Sukhumvit Soi 3" means house/building number 25 on the 3rd soi of Sukhumvit Road. While the soi numbers on each side will always advance upward, the numbers often do not advance evenly between sides — for example, Soi 55 could be across from Soi 36. Many well-known sois have an additional name, which can be used instead of the number. Sukhumvit Soi 3



is also known as "Soi Nana Nuea", so the address above might thus also be expressed as "25 Soi Nana Nuea". The extension /x is used for new streets created between existing streets, as seen in Sukhumvit's soi pattern 7, 7/1, 7/2, 9, 11. Some short alleys are called **trok** (ตรอก) instead of soi.

To make things a little more complex, some large sois like Soi Ekkamai (Sukhumvit Soi 63) and Soi Ari (Phahonyothin Soi 7) have their own sois. In these cases, an address like "Ari Soi 3" means "the 3rd soi off Soi Ari", and you may even spot addresses like "68/2 Ekkamai Soi 4, Sukhumvit Road", meaning "2nd house beside house 68, in the 4th soi of Ekkamai, which is the 63rd soi of Sukhumvit". In many sois, the house numbers are not simply increasing, but may spread around.

To further bewilder the tourist who doesn't read Thai, the renderings of Thai street names in the Latin alphabet are not consistent. The road running towards Don Mueang Airport from Victory Monument may be spelled *Phahonyothin* or *Phahon Yothin* or *Pahon Yothin* or *Phaholyothin* depending on which street sign or map you consult. It's all the same in Thai, of course, only the romanisation varies.



The Skytrain on raised tracks lets commuters and tourists avoid the traffic 

And if that's not confusing enough, most of the larger streets tend to change names altogether every few kilometres. Sukhumvit is called *Sukhumvit* on one side of the tollway (roughly east), but it becomes *Phloen Chit* just before you cross Witthayu Road (aka *Wireless Road*) going towards the river. Keep going just a few more streets and it becomes *Rama I Road* (or *Phra Ram Neung Road*) after you pass Ratchadamri Road. But if you were to turn right onto Ratchadamri, in just a few blocks you'll find yourself on *Ratchaprarop Road* (past Phetchaburi, aka *New Phetburi*, which is called *Phitsanulok* closer to the river).

Fortunately, there's logic to these name changes: most of them are neighbourhoods. It wouldn't make sense to call the road *Sukhumvit* if it's no longer running through the Sukhumvit area, would it? Thus, Sukhumvit becomes *Phloen Chit* where it runs through the Phloen Chit area. It's when you're able to grasp the city in terms of its neighbourhoods that it both becomes more navigable and more charming. Likewise, Pratunam and Chatuchak are much more than just markets; they're neighbourhoods, each with their own distinct character.

Compass directions are not widely used by Thais to navigate in Bangkok. Thus, asking for directions in terms of "Is that west from here?" will probably earn you little more than a confused look from a local. You're better off to familiarise yourself with the neighbourhoods and navigate to and from them. "How do I get to Thong Lo?" will get you there faster than asking for directions to *Sukhumvit Soi 55*.

One exception: the Chao Phraya River is the landmark in Bangkok, and many directional references can be made as "toward the river" or "away from the river". If you aren't too close, that is: since the river winds around the most popular tourist areas, river references tend to be most helpful when you're wandering farther afield than Khao San Road, Sanam Luang or Rattanakosin. And wander you should.

## Climate

According to the World Meteorological Organization, Bangkok is the world's hottest city. Just 14 degrees north of the equator, Bangkok is sunny at all times of the year with temperatures over 32 °C (90 °F).

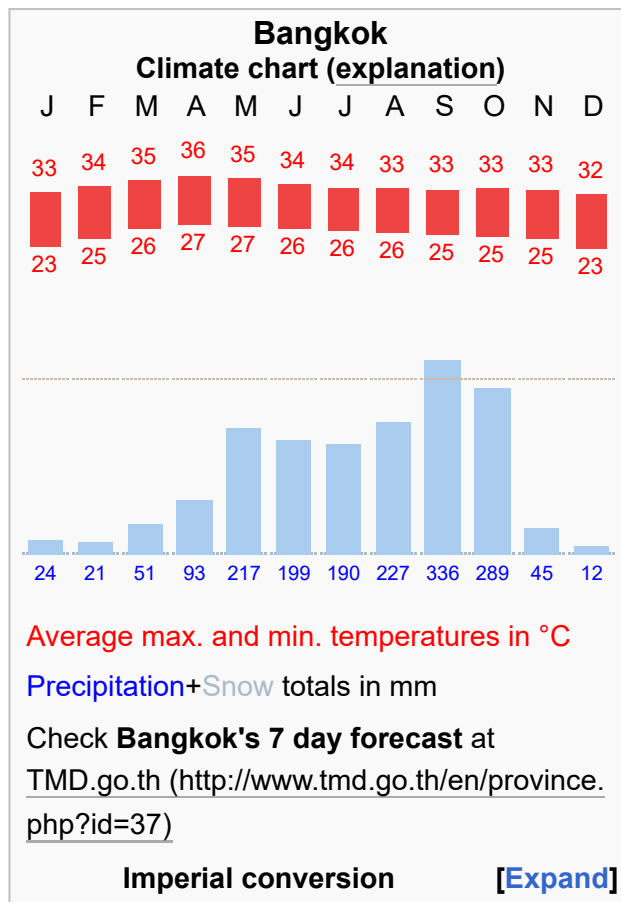
The most pleasant time to visit is the **cool season** that lasts from Nov-Feb. It is both the coolest and driest period — the Emerald Buddha statue in Wat Phra Kaeo even wears a scarf during this period! Don't think that's necessary though — daytime temperatures still hover around 32 °C (90 °F), but it does cool down to around 23 °C (73 °F), and on rare occasions can even dip as low as 15°C. March and April represent the **hot season**, and hot it is — 35 °C (95 °F) on average. Average heat indices are around 42 °C (108 °F) during the day and 30 °C (86 °F) at night, but don't be surprised to see heat indices rising to 48 °C (118 °F) or higher, with nighttime heat indices around 36 °C (97 °F). This is the worst season to visit Bangkok, so plan in a lot of air-conditioned shopping mall visits and get a hotel with a swimming pool. Then there's the **wet season** that runs from May-Oct. Expect massive downpours resulting in floods all over the city, and spells of thunder at times. It's not all bad though — the afternoon showers are actually a pleasant way to cool down from the heat, and while they may last all day, usually they're over within an hour. Extreme rainfall happens in September and October, so these months are best avoided.

Whatever season you're visiting, don't take the weather lightly — temple-tramping in the scorching afternoon sun can be a challenge, so come well-prepared. **Dress lightly** for the weather, but keep in mind that **some palaces and temples** (notably the Grand Palace) **have a strict dress code**, i.e., everyone must fully cover their torso, legs and upper arms. So shorts, halter tops, etc. will deny you entry. At entrances to some major attractions, vendors may rent needed coverage.

Also be sure you **drink enough fluids**! You have no excuse not to, as 7-Elevens and other convenience stores are abundant in Bangkok and sell cooled beverages for as little as 10 baht. Locals get their water from "reverse osmosis" purified water machines that fill up a one-litre bottle for 1 baht, but the potability for visitors may vary.

## Listen

- *The Bangkok Podcast* (<https://www.bangkokpodcast.com/>). A long-running podcast produced by two ex-pats living in Bangkok. Featuring special guests and unique stories focussed on ex-pats' and travellers' experiences in Bangkok.



## Read

- *Comrade Aeon's Field Guide to Bangkok* by Emma Larkin. A multi-faceted book narrated by diverse characters who are trying to find their own path through the difficulties and opportunities presented by this chaotic and vibrant city.

## Watch

Foreign films were popular in Thailand from the get-go, but in the 1920s a local film industry started to emerge in Bangkok. The most critically acclaimed Thai films were produced in the "three waves" of the Thai film industry, the 1930s, the 1950s and the late 1990s/early 2000s, although films made before World War II have unfortunately been lost. Predominant genres are action, historical epics, romance and gay/transgender films, almost always intertwined with elements of comedy. The following are staged (at least partly) in Bangkok:

- *6ixtynin9* (เรื่องตลก 69, Pen-ek Ratanaruang, 1999). Tum, a secretary just fired from a financial corporation during the Asian financial crisis, discovers an instant noodle box in front of her door. It is filled with money and she decides to keep it. However, the people that left it there soon want it back.
- *Bangkok Dangerous* (บางกอกแดนเจอร์ส เพชฌฆาตเงียบ อันตราย, The Pang Brothers, 1999). The debut of the Pang Brothers, *Bangkok Dangerous* is a stylish film about a hitman who finds love, and realises how his actions are hurting good people.
- *The Beach* (Danny Boyle, 2000). Richard (played by Leonardo DiCaprio) is a young American backpacker looking for adventure. In Khao San Road, he meets Daffy, who gives him a map to a secret island. It is a popular film in the backpacker community. Besides Bangkok, some scenes in this Hollywood production are filmed in Ko Phi Phi, a beach island in the south of Thailand.
- *Citizen Dog* (หมานคร, Wisit Sasanatieng, 2004). An eccentric, bright, colour-splashed film that follows the life of Pod as he moves to Bangkok from the countryside. Without a goal in life, Pod falls in love with Jin, a girl who lives for her dreams. It gives a playfully ironic portrait of Bangkok, the city that offers false dreams and real disillusionment.
- *The Hangover Part II* (Todd Phillips, 2011). American comedy film about a group of friends (the "wolf pack") who travel to Bangkok for a bachelor party. A lot of stereotypes are confirmed, but it is still a good laugh. Most scenes of the film are shot in Yaowarat, Sukhumvit and Thonburi. The State Tower in Silom is also featured.
- *Iron Ladies* (สตรีเหล็ก, Youngyooth Thongkonthun, 2000). This film follows the true story of a men's volleyball team that almost entirely consists of gay and transgender players. The team competes for the 1996 national championships, and while the crowd loves them, they are being judged by other teams and match officials.
- *Ong-Bak: Muay Thai Warrior* (องค์บาก, Prachya Pinkaew, 2003). Martial-arts star Tony Jaa's breakthrough film and an absolute must-see for those interested in Muay Thai or fight choreography. Many locations in Bangkok are featured, but don't think Khao San Road is the underground fighting den as it is portrayed.

## Tourist information

- Bangkok tourist information (<https://www.tourismthailand.org/About-Thailand/Destination/Bangkok>)

# Talk

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The main language in Bangkok is the central dialect of Thai, which differs somewhat from the northern dialect spoken around Chiang Mai. However, due to the presence of large numbers of tourists, many people working in the service industry have a basic grasp of English, as do staff at many of the popular food stalls.

Bangkok is also home to a large ethnic Chinese community, many of whom are bilingual in Teochew and Thai. Mandarin is also increasingly widely spoken in tourism industry to cater to the large number of Chinese tourists.

The MRT and BTS station signage includes both Thai and English, and ticket counter staff usually know enough English to serve you. Most taxi drivers cannot speak English, so therefore have your hotel receptionist show your taxi driver the address in Thai. Other European languages are not widespread in Bangkok.

## Get in

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### By plane

Bangkok is served by two airports: **Suvarnabhumi Airport** (**BKK** <sup>IATA</sup>) (pronounced *Soo-wahn-nah-poom*) and **Don Mueang Airport** (**DMK** <sup>IATA</sup>). Suvarnabhumi Airport is the main airport and used by all full-service airlines, but Nok Air, Air Asia, and some other low cost carriers use Don Mueang Airport. Both airports lie about 30 km (19 mi) out on opposite sides of the city, so be prepared for a long ride to get into the city centre, and an even longer ride to transfer between them. A free transfer bus between the two airports is available if you can show an appropriate boarding pass. On a good day this takes about an hour, but the highway is often badly congested, so always allow 2–3 hr for this transfer. It is a good idea to have Thai baht ready for connecting to the city. Good money changing options are available at the BKK metro station.

### Suvarnabhumi Airport

*Main article: Suvarnabhumi Airport*

**1 Suvarnabhumi Airport (<http://suvarnabhumiairport.com/>)** (สุวรรณภูมิ **BKK** <sup>IATA</sup>) (30 km (19 mi) east of Bangkok). Space-age Suvarnabhumi Airport started operations in Sep 2006 and is now Bangkok's main airport and one of the busiest airports in Southeast Asia. It is used for international and domestic flights to Bangkok. There is only one terminal building, which covers both domestic and international flights. It is *huge*, and by some measures the world's largest, so allow time for getting around. There are two



A spartan gate lounge





immigration sections, but processing time can be lengthy, at least 30 min and on bad days almost 2 hr.

On the basement level of the passenger terminal, the **Airport Rail Link** (<http://srtet.co.th/index.php/en/>) offers a speedy train service to downtown. There are no express services, but the all-stops commuter line is still a great way of avoiding Bangkok's horrendous rush hour traffic, particularly when it's raining. Trains depart 06:00-midnight every day, with a train every 10-13 min, and after Makkasan station they continue to Ratchaprarop (transfer to MRT) and Phaya Thai (Skytrain) stations. The ride to Phaya Thai takes 26 min from the airport and costs 45 baht.

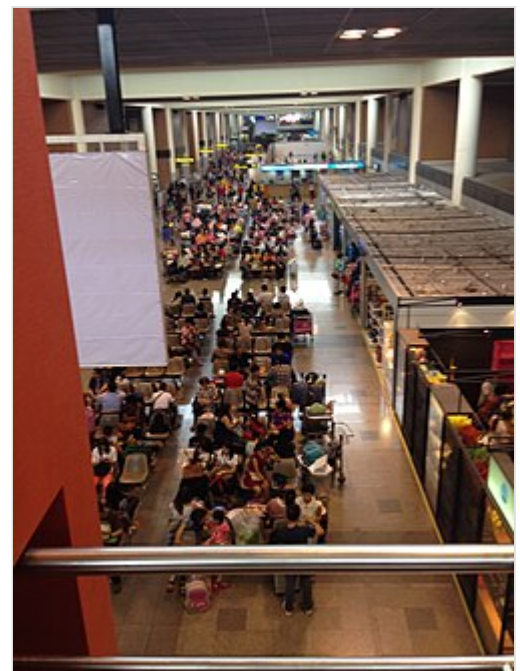
You can also take a free shuttle bus to the airport bus terminal aka Transportation Centre to catch inexpensive city buses. These may be convenient if you are going to a suburban area like Rangsit or Bang Kapi. Since June 2017 express bus **S1** runs from the terminal building to Khao San Road.

If you need a taxi, ordinary **metered taxis** are available on the first floor (one floor below arrivals). Follow the "public taxi" signs that lead to the official taxi queue outside of the airport premises. Avoid the touts in the arrival hall; the taxis they are trying to get you into are mostly likely illegal, and the risk of getting ripped off is much higher with them. ATM-style ticket booths dispense numbered slips, with the number indicating the bay in which your taxi is parked. You can choose between a normal taxi good for 2 adults with baggage and a big taxi. Keep the slip since it helps to make a complaint if the driver scams you. There is a surcharge on top of the meter (*not* per passenger), meaning that trips to the city will cost 250-400 baht plus possible expressway tolls of 50 and 25 baht (March 2020) depending on route. Make sure you have change ready to pass to the toll operators to avoid being overcharged for the tolls later on. The ride takes about 45–60 min depending on traffic and destination.

## Don Mueang Airport

**2 Don Mueang Airport** (<https://donmueang.airportthai.co.th/>) (ดอนเมือง DMK <sup>IATA</sup>) (*about 30 km (19 mi) north of Sukhumvit*). This was Bangkok's main airport until 2006. These days, the airport primarily caters to budget carriers, and handles flights by **Thai** **Lion Air** (<http://lionairthai.com/en/>), **Nok Air** (<http://nokair.com>) and **Air Asia** (<http://airasia.com>). It is a bit harder to reach DMK than BKK due to the absence of a practical rail connection. (updated Feb 2026 | )

1. **Taxi** : the *public taxi stand* is on the end of the arrival area. Follow the signs to the taxi stand. (Don't be fooled by all the taxi service booths in the main hall.) The same booth and slip system as at Suvarnabhumi Airport is used here. If the queue at the taxi stand is long or you need a more spacious car, you may want to book a (so-called) *limousine taxi* from the desks in the terminal. This will get you a slightly nicer car at about twice the price. There is also an unofficial taxi queue (but for proper metered taxis) on the main road right outside the terminal, to get there, use the



Inside the drab but functional Don Mueang airport



bridge towards the railway station, but get off down the narrow staircase *before* crossing the main road (using this queue can cut the wait considerably and avoid the airport surcharge). Ignore any touts outside and do not get into any car with white licence plates, as these are not licenced to carry passengers.

2. **Special Bus + Skytrain (BTS)** : The **A1** airport bus runs to the Sena Nikhom BTS station. You can board it at exit 6 of Terminal 1 and exit 12 of Terminal 2. It runs from the airport 07:30-24:00 and to the airport 07:00-24:00. 30 baht collected by a steward on board once the bus leaves. Takes about 20 min and uses the Don Muang elevated tollway to avoid traffic jams. The bus can be very crowded, so make sure you stand early on the line. Most have Wi-Fi if you have a local sim to SMS register. After Sena Nikhom the bus continues to Ratchayothin BTS station and Vibhavadi hospital before returning to the airport. If you are going to the *Victory Monument* area, taking the **A2** bus saves the trouble of switching onto the train (fare also 30 baht).
3. **Express Bus**: Since May 2017 **A3** bus runs on the route Don Mueang - Dindaeng - Pratunam - Ratchaprasong - Ratchadamri - Lumphini Park, and **A4** bus runs on the route Don Mueang - Yommarach - Lam Luang - Phan Fa - Democracy Monument - Khao San - Sanam Luang. Fares are 50 baht and buses pick up passengers at door #6 of Terminal 1 and door #12 of Terminal 2 between 07:00 and 23:00.
4. **Train**: across a covered overpass from the airport is *Don Mueang Train Station*. While the rickety old local services have been replaced by a modern commuter service running every 12-20 minutes, these terminate at Bang Sue in northern Bangkok, where you'll need to change to the MRT Blue Line to get anywhere useful.
5. **LimoBus** (<http://limobus.co.th/>) : This private bus service has one route serving Khao San Road and another route serving Silom and Pratunam. It is cheaper than metered taxi for a solo traveller but significantly more expensive than city buses.
6. **City Bus** : There are also a number of public transport buses going by the airport, just follow the signs out toward the train station. Buses towards central Bangkok are at the airport's side of the road, so don't cross the highway. These are useful bus lines :
  - Air-conditioned bus **504** will take you to CentralWorld at Ratchaprasong intersection (close to Siam Square), as well as to Lumphini Park and Silom, from where you can have access to the Skytrain.
  - Ordinary and air-conditioned bus **29** will take you to Hualamphong Train Station passing by many places, including Victory Monument and Siam Square. You can also get off at the Chatuchak Weekend Market, where you can switch onto the metro or Skytrain. Sometimes the final stop is Victory Monument (19 baht).
  - Air-conditioned bus **59** will take you to Sanam Luang in Rattanakosin. This route is time-consuming as Rattanakosin is far off from the airport.
  - Keep in mind that some of these city buses don't complete the route. They are called "additional bus" (Thai: รถเสริม *rot serm*). These kind of buses have a red sign in front of them with the final destination written on it (in Thai script of course). Check this before taking the bus. You can ask the locals at the bus stop or a conductor on the bus.

## By train

*See also: Thailand § Get around*

Trains are run by the State Railway of Thailand (<https://www.dticket.railway.co.th/DTicketPublicWeb/home/Home>).

Railways converge on Bangkok from all parts of the country: Chiang Mai to the north, Nong Khai on the Laos border, Ubon Ratchathani to the east, Ban Klong Luk on the Cambodia border, Sattahip on the coast to the south, Nam Tok to the west, and Padang Besar on the Malaysia border.

Tickets for travel on any trains departing Bangkok may be purchased from any of the larger train stations, as well as online from the official SRT ticketing website D-Ticket (<https://www.dticket.railway.co.th/DTicketPublicWeb/home/Home>) or various resellers such as 12go. Bangkok is the only place in Thailand where travellers can reserve tickets over the phone (the 24-hour SRT hotline is 1690 and they have English-speaking operators), because tickets must be paid for at one of many train stations in Bangkok by 22:00 the next day. The official website is not easy to use: tourists report problems with incomplete translations on the English version of the website, as well as with registering an account and setting up payment methods.

As of 2023, the name **Bangkok** in the SRT intercity timetable refers to the new **Krung Thep Aphiwat** terminal. There is **one exception**: the Eastern Line service to Ban Klong Luk on the Cambodian border, where **Bangkok** means the historic **Hua Lamphong** station.

Some tourists prefer to buy from agents like 12go, that have easy-to-use websites and English-speaking customer service. All agents charge extra fees for their services.

A high speed railway is under construction between Bangkok and Vientiane, Laos, with a plan to continue it southward into Malaysia and Singapore.

**3 Hua Lamphong Station.** An old stately terminal, this is **no longer the main railway station in Bangkok**. It's central, near Yaowarat and has its own metro station. It's a charming old building of 1916, yet surprisingly efficient and convenient. On timetables, it's usually called "Bangkok" in English or "Krung Thep" in Thai. Tickets for commuter trains leaving the same or the next day can be bought at the counters under the big screens. The only intercity train that terminates here is the **Eastern Line** from Ban Klong Luk on the Cambodian border.



Hua Lamphong, the historic terminus



**4 Krung Thep Aphiwat Central Terminal.** Unofficially Bang Sue Grand Station, this is **now the terminus for most inter-city trains**. The station is directly connected to the MRT Blue line station of the same name, and is connected by Bus 52 to Mo Chit, for the long-distance bus terminal. It is the largest railway station in Southeast Asia, with 26 platforms; some 600 metres long.

**5 Thonburi Train Station** (ธนบุรี formerly Bangkok Noi Station) (*west of the river in Thonburi*). The terminus for twice-daily trains to Kanchanaburi (via Nakhon Pathom). Just to keep things confusing, the previous Thonburi Train Station right next to the river (accessible by the Chao Phraya Express Boat pier Railway Station) is now mothballed and turned into a museum, but it's only 800 m away from the new station. The weekend-only second class air conditioned tourist trains to Kanchanaburi and Nam Tok depart from Hualamphong Train Station.



The Mae Klong market train departs from Wongwian Yai



**6 Wongwian Yai Train Station (วงเวียนใหญ่)** (About 800 m from the Skytrain station of the same name. To get there, take a metered taxi or walk (using a map)). Serves the rustic Mae Klong commuter line to the fishing village of Maha Chai. Trains run roughly hourly and the trip takes about one hour. The ride is of little interest if you want to get there fast, but is an experience for rail fans and an attraction in itself, with a nice view on the countryside's orchards, vegetable plantations and coconut groves. Maha Chai is a nice seafood destination, and if you feel like it, you can cross the Tha Chin river by ferry and continue by rail to Samut Songkhram. Tickets for trains departing from other stations are not sold at Wongwian Yai Train Station.

## By boat

Not many people come to Bangkok by cruise ship. Medium to large ships must dock at **7 Laem Chabang Port**. about 90+ min (varies considerably in rush hours) southeast of Bangkok and about 30 min north of Pattaya. A taxi service desk is available on the wharf, but charges extortionate prices for a trip to Bangkok, to charter a taxi (4 passengers), or to charter a minibus (usually 11 passenger seats). Slightly lower prices can be found by walking out to the main road and taking a minibus, but even these rates are still almost double the typical rate in the opposite direction. Better deals may be possible for round trips (even if returning the following day).

If you can easily get to and from the following bus terminals...

- Frequent first and second class bus services directly connect Laem Chabang with Bangkok's Eastern Bus Terminal (Ekkamai); less frequent direct services run to the Northeastern Bus Terminal (Mo Chit). A first class air conditioned bus (blue and white) to either will take 90 min or less. A quick way to get into Sukhumvit is to get an Ekkamai-bound bus and then disembark early at On Nut, where you can hop onto the Skytrain. The bus will always stop here if a passenger requests it.
- Southbound buses to Pattaya can be boarded at the traffic lights on Sukhumvit Road in Laem Chabang. These are extremely frequent (at least 10 per hour).

Smaller ships may dock well upriver at **8 Khlong Toei** (Bangkok Cruise Port). close to the city's center. Reaching major hotels and the many major points of interest is cheaper and much quicker than from Laem Chabang. A modest terminal provides processing for passengers. You'll also find "managers" inside who arrange tours and taxis. Costs can vary widely according to your negotiating skills or if you have the option of using a ship's shuttle other locations. The facility is within an active freight port. (Its entrance is not close to the metro stop of the same name.) The distance to the very-active port entrance from the terminal (about a kilometer) and heavy traffic in-between mean pedestrians are not allowed. Thus, options to get to/from the terminal are metered taxi and ship's bus/shuttle if offered.

## By bus

When buying tickets for buses out of Bangkok, it's best to skip travel agents and their private buses, and get the tickets for public buses directly at Bangkok's three **public bus terminals**. These buses are cheaper, safer, faster, more comfortable and won't scam you onto a clapped-out minibus halfway along the way or to a bedbug-infested hotel at the end. Each of these long haul bus terminals serve a different direction. They are purposefully located in off-central locations, so the long-haul buses avoid the heavy traffic congestion in the centre of the city. They are:

- **9 Eastern Bus Terminal** (Ekkamai (เอกมัย)), ☎ +66 2 391-2504. A relatively compact terminal right next to Ekkamai BTS station in Sukhumvit. Ekkamai serves destinations in



Eastern Thailand, including Pattaya, Rayong, Ban Phe (for Ko Samet), Chanthaburi and Trat. If you're heading for Ko Chang, there is a specifically designated stop for it between Chanthaburi and Trat. You can also get a bus to the Cambodian border crossing at Poipet, look for the bus to Aranyaprathet and tell them you are going to Poipet when you buy the ticket.

- **10 Northern and Northeastern Bus Terminal** (Mo Chit 2 (หมอชิต 2), ☎ +66 2 9362841 (-3)). The largest, busiest, and most modern terminal, replacing the old Mo Chit terminal. The upper floor serves the Isaan region in the northeast of Thailand. The ground floor serves Northern Thailand, and shares some destinations with Ekkamai (including Pattaya, Rayong, Chanthaburi and Trat). The bus terminal is a fair hike from BTS station Mo Chit or MRT station Chatuchak Park. Motorbike taxis do the trip for a fixed fare (bargaining is pointless), while tuk-tuks charge whatever they feel like — when bargaining, remember that a real taxi with air conditioning will cost you about the same as a motortaxi (assuming little traffic). You can also take **Bus 77** and pay the flat fare on board (this bus also goes from the terminal via Victory Monument, Pratunam, and Silom Rd). If you have a considerable amount of luggage, the easiest, if not necessarily fastest, option is to take a taxi directly to or from the bus terminal.
  - Buying tickets at the terminal is reasonably easy: find a window with your destination written on it (in friendly Roman letters), pay the fare in big numbers on the same window, and you'll get a ticket on the next available departure. Blue writing means 1st class, red means 2nd class (avoid on longer trips), and tickets for destinations in Isaan are sold from the third floor. Ask the information desk on the first floor if you need help, or any of the Transport Co. staff, easily identifiable thanks to their natty white shirts with gold buttons. Next just find the departure stall and you're on your way. If you have time to kill, there are two fairly decent air-conditioned food courts at both ends of the main terminal building, plus KFC, Dunkin' Donuts, and lots of 7-Eleven outlets.
  - Air-conditioned buses are available directly from Bangkok Mo Chit to Siem Reap, Cambodia. Transport Co. (<http://home.transport.co.th/index.php/en/>), the state-owned company running the buses, offers daily services to Siem Reap. Departures every day at 08:00 and 09:00 in both directions.
- **11 Southern Bus Terminal** (Sai Tai Mai (สายใต้ใหม่)), Phutthamonthon Sai 1 Rd, Thonburi, ☎ +66 2 894-6122. Serves all destinations west and south of Bangkok from its somewhat inconvenient location on the Thonburi side of the river. Long-distance buses leave from here to destinations throughout Western Thailand (including Nakhon Pathom and Kanchanaburi) and Southern Thailand (including Krabi, Phuket, Surat Thani, Ko Samui, Ko Pha Ngan, Hat Yai, and others). The new terminal is a fairly pleasant airport-like structure with air-conditioning, electronic departure monitors (in English), a few bank offices, and fast food restaurants. The ground floor houses mostly Thai restaurants outside. The first floor has ticket sales and most restaurants. The third floor is a small shopping mall and is a good place to sprawl on the floor if you have a long layover. Unlike the rip-off operators at Khao San Road, all buses from here are public, well-regulated, cheap, and reasonably safe. Just buy your tickets at the numbered desk with your destination posted on it (almost always in English). (updated Jan 2018 | )
  - Getting to the terminal is a bit of headache, as public transport is limited. The easiest option is to take a metered taxi, but if you're going there in the evening, especially during workdays, be prepared to fight a serious traffic jam — getting there can take 30 min or a full hour from the city centre. Ignore touts at Khao San Road — unlike what they might say, there really is no "faster" way when all the roads are congested.
  - From Victory Monument BTS station, the terminal can be reached with pale orange air-conditioned **Bus 515**. When approached by the conductor, just say "Sai Tai". After quite a ride, the large bus terminal will be on the left side about 9 km (5.5 mi) after crossing the river (you won't miss it and probably will be told as well). Getting there by bus actually does not take much more time than taxi (it's almost the same in the likely case of a traffic jam), but the ride is much cheaper, especially if alone. **Bus 556** no longer goes from

Suvarnabhumi Airport, but from Makkasan Airport Rail Link (ARL) station. There are also white minibuses from various points around Bangkok, e.g., from Ramkhamhaeng (near Rajamangala National Stadium). There are inexpensive shuttle buses and slightly more expensive (but quicker loading and a bit faster) minibuses to and from the Northeastern Bus Terminal as well.

## By van

For travelling to Bangkok suburbs or locations within 200 km of the city, the fastest and often the cheapest way is to use public van (minibus) services. They run from parking lots beside the **12 Victory Monument Square** (Thai:อนุสาวรีย์ *anusawarii*) (*Use footbridge leading north from BTS Victory Monument exit 2*). . Facing the monument itself are the city bus stops, behind it there is a small market, and behind the market you will find many white-coloured minibuses just parking at the roadside and waiting for passengers. They depart when full, usually each 10–30 min. Fare is usually similar to long-distance buses with the same destination (if there are any). Other way, it could be estimated as 1 baht/km.

Since October 2016 the minibuses to other provinces have been relocated to the three public bus terminals which makes them far less convenient. The city is easing the transition by providing free shuttle buses from Victory Monument Square to the bus terminals. The shuttles to Southern Bus Terminal, and Northern and Northeastern Bus Terminal depart from the northwestern quadrant of the square. It is unclear how long these free shuttles will remain in place.

Destinations are written on the front and the side of the minibuses in Thai, so you should ask drivers or ticket sellers about your destination. Minivans are usually the fastest way of transportation because they take elevated expressways right from Victory Monument, thus avoiding traffic jams. Another advantage is that they start from the city centre of Bangkok and usually arrive at the city centre of their destination. Normal long-distance buses sometimes stop further away from the city centre. Minibus drivers are infamous for unsafe driving and deadly accidents. A disadvantage of minibuses is that leg room is limited, and might be not comfortable for tall people. If you have bulky baggage you either keep it on your lap or buy a seat for it.

Some useful destinations within the city: Min Buri (for Siam Park), Nava Nakorn (for Don Mueang Airport or to get out along hwy 1 for hitching to the north/northeast), Phra Ram 2 (to the highway, for hitching to southern Thailand), Suvarnabhumi Airport.

Some destinations served from **Eastern Bus Terminal**: Pattaya, Ban Phe (for Ko Samet), Rayong, Chanthaburi.

Some destinations served from **Northern and Northeastern Bus Terminal**: Ayutthaya, Lopburi.

Some destinations served from **Southern Bus Terminal**: Samut Songkhram, Samut Sakhon, Kanchanaburi, Phetchaburi, Hua Hin.

## By car

Getting into Bangkok by car is not a good idea, as you can easily waste half a day waiting in traffic just to get to the other side of the city. Three major highways lead to Bangkok from every direction in Thailand. The best way to get to Bangkok from Northern Thailand is via

**Phahonyothin Road** (Rte 1), which comes from Mae Sai near the Myanmar border. **Sukhumvit Road** (Rte 3) comes from cities in Eastern Thailand, such as Trat, Pattaya, and Chonburi. **Phetkasem Road** (Rte 4), one of the longest roads in the world, extends all the way to the Malaysian border, serving Southern Thailand.

To ease congestion on these highways, a new system of motorways has emerged which will be extended in the future. The **New Bangkok-Chonburi Motorway** (Motorway 7) connects Chonburi and Pattaya. The **Kanchanaphisek National Highway** (Motorway 9 or "Outer Ring Road") makes a giant loop around Bangkok serving most satellite towns around it such as Nonthaburi and Samut Prakan.



Traffic in Bangkok

## Get around

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Bangkok has a decent public transportation network by Southeast Asian standards, but much room for improvement lies in its integration. Bangkok is notorious for its traffic jams, so visitors are advised to rely on the rail and river networks whenever possible. Transit Bangkok (<http://transitbangkok.com/>) is a journey planner that can help you choose the best route.

### By train

Three separate operators form the Bangkok rail network: the **Skytrain (BTS)** (<https://www.bts.co.th/eng/>), the **Metro (MRT)** (<https://www.mrta.co.th/en/>), and the **State Railway of Thailand (SRT)** (<http://www.srtet.co.th/index.php/en/>). Each operator has a different fare system, meaning you will have to buy a separate ticket or stored value card for each network you wish to use. Fare payments can be made by tapping a contactless Mastercard or Visa on the fare gates of all MRT and SRT lines, but not the BTS lines. Whilst transferring between operators is relatively straightforward, different names are used for some interchange stations. For instance, the interchange station known as Asok in the BTS system is known as Sukhumvit in the MRT system. Trains are generally clean, modern and reliable, with signs and announcements in Thai and English.

### Skytrain

The **13 Skytrain (BTS)** (<http://www.bts.co.th/en>) operates three lines. The light green **Sukhumvit Line** travels from **Khu Khot** (N24) in the north to **Kheha** (E23) in the south. The dark green **Silom Line** travels from **Bang Wa** (S12) in the west to **National Stadium** (W1) in the city centre. The **Gold Line** travels from **Krung Thon Buri** (G1) to **Khlong San** (G3). (updated Apr 2024 | )

Tickets are zone-based. You can buy and reload a "Rabbit" card at all stations. A new card costs 200 baht, including 100 baht stored value, and a 100 baht non-refundable issuing fee. Your passport is required to buy the card. You can make payments at some convenience stores, restaurants and supermarkets with the card. Alternatively, you can buy a One-Day Pass for 150 baht per day. Single journey cards can be purchased at ticket counters and vending machines. All

vending machines accept coins (Thai baht only). Some vending machines accept 20, 50 and 100 baht notes but there is often a queue to use them. Single journey cards are tapped on the scanner to enter and deposited in the slot to exit. Fare payments cannot yet be made by tapping a contactless Mastercard or Visa on the fare gates.



Bangkok BTS, MRT, SRT and BRT Map

The Skytrain serves various tourist attractions. The Sukhumvit Line and the Silom Line converge at **Siam** (CEN), the epicentre of modern Bangkok. The Sukhumvit Line passes Victory Monument and Chatuchak Weekend Market. The Silom Line passes Patpong Night Market and the Chao Phraya river. Khao San Road can be reached by taking the Silom Line to **Saphan Taksin** (S6) and transferring to a Chao Phraya Express Boat traveling from Sathorn Pier to Phra Arthit Pier. There are interchanges with the Metro at **Bang Wa** (S12), **Sala Daeng** (S2), **Asok** (E4) and **Mo Chit** (N7).

The Skytrain operates between 06:00 and 00:00.

## Metro

The **Metro (MRT)** operates four lines. The **Blue** line travels in a circle from Lak Song to Tha Phra through Thonburi, Yaowarat, Silom, Sukhumvit, Ratchadaphisek and Chatuchak Weekend Market in Phahonyothin. The **Purple** line travels from Tao Poon to Nonthaburi across the Chao Phraya River. The **Yellow** line travels from Lat Phrao to Samrong. The **Pink** line travels from Nonthaburi to Min Buri.



Tickets are distance-based. Fare payments can be made by tapping a contactless Mastercard or Visa on the fare gates (Apple Pay and Google Pay are not yet accepted). Alternatively, you can buy and reload a "Mangmoom" card at all stations. A new card costs 250 baht, including 100 baht stored value, and a 150 baht non-refundable issuing fee. Single journey tokens can be purchased at ticket counters and vending machines. All vending machines accept coins and banknotes (Thai baht only). Single journey tokens are tapped on the scanner to enter and deposited in the slot to exit.

The Metro serves various tourist attractions. Sanam Chai is near **Wat Pho** and the **Grand Palace**. Wat Mangkon provides good access to Yaowarat. Si Lom and Lumphini are at either end of **Lumphini Park**. Phetchaburi provides an interchange with **Saen Saep Express Boat** at Asok Pier. Phra Ram 9 is near **Fortunetown IT Mall** which locals consider better than Pantip Plaza. Thailand Cultural Centre is near **Rot Fai Ratchada** night market. Lat Phrao is near **Suan Lum** night bazaar. If you're going to the **Chatuchak Weekend Market**, don't get out at Chatuchak Park, but go one stop further to Kamphaeng Phet as it drops you right inside the market. There are interchanges with the Skytrain at **Bang Wa, Si Lom, Sukhumvit** and **Chatuchak Park**.

The Metro operates between 06:00 and 00:00.

### State Railway of Thailand

The State Railway of Thailand (SRT) operates the Airport Rail Link, the Dark Red line, the Light Red line and the Greater Bangkok Commuter Rail.

The **Airport Rail Link** (<http://srtet.co.th/index.php/en/>) **ARL** connects Suvarnabhumi Airport to **Makkasan** for the Metro and **Phaya Thai** for the Skytrain. The express train and the City Air Terminal at Makkasan no longer operate but the commuter train is still useful for visitors. The ride from Suvarnabhumi to Makkasan costs just 35 baht and takes 22 minutes (cheaper and faster than a taxi). The ride from Suvarnabhumi to Phaya Thai costs just 45 baht and takes 27 minutes (also cheaper and faster than a taxi).

Tickets are distance-based. Fare payments can be made by tapping a contactless Mastercard or Visa on the fare gates (Apple Pay and Google Pay are not yet accepted). Alternatively, single journey tokens can be purchased at ticket counters and vending machines. All vending machines accept coins and banknotes (Thai baht only). Single journey tokens are tapped on the scanner to enter and deposited in the slot to exit.

The Airport Rail Link can get very crowded at rush hour, but you are likely to find a seat if boarding from either end at Phaya Thai or Suvarnabhumi. There are escalators and lifts if you have baggage, but no luggage racks on the trains. At Makkasan station you can roll your bags along a footbridge to Phetchaburi Metro station. At Phaya Thai station most passengers walk forward to the staircases. You need to turn backward in the direction in which the train arrived for lifts and escalators. You can then roll your bags along a footbridge to Phaya Thai Skytrain station.

The Airport Rail Link operates between 06:00 and 00:00.

The **Dark Red Line** connects Bang Sue and Rangsit, stopping at Don Mueang for connections to Don Mueang International Airport. The **Light Red Line** connects Bang Sue and Taling Chan, for connections to Taling Chan Floating Market.

Tickets are distance-based. Fare payments can be made by tapping a contactless Mastercard or Visa on the fare gates (Apple Pay and Google Pay are not yet accepted). Alternatively, you can buy and reload a "Stored Value Ticket" card at all stations. A new card costs 300 baht, including 200 baht stored value, 50 baht refundable deposit, and a 50 baht non-refundable issuing fee. Single journey tokens can be purchased at ticket counters and vending machines. All vending machines accept coins and banknotes (Thai baht only). Single journey tokens are tapped on the scanner to enter and deposited in the slot to exit.

Both lines operate between 05:00 and 00:00.

The **Greater Bangkok Commuter Rail** consists of several suburban lines running to and from the outskirts of the city during rush hour and is of little use to tourists.

## By boat

### Chao Phraya Express Boat



An "orange flag" Chao Phraya Express Boat



A ride on the **Chao Phraya River** should be high on any tourist's agenda. The cheapest and most popular option is the **Chao Phraya Express Boat** (<http://www.chaophrayaexpressboat.com/en/home/>), basically an aquatic bus cruising up and down the river. The basic service goes from **Wat Rajsingkorn** (S4) all the way north to **Nonthaburi** (N30), with stops at most of **Rattanakosin's** major attractions including the Grand Palace (at **Tha Chang**) and Wat Pho (at **Tha Tien**). The closest pier to **Khao San Road** is **Phra Arthit**. Enter the express boat at the numerous piers and pay the

conductor for the trip. She will approach you bearing a long metal ticket dispenser. At some bigger piers you can buy the ticket before boarding. When the metal cylinder lady approaches you, just show her the ticket you bought on the pier.

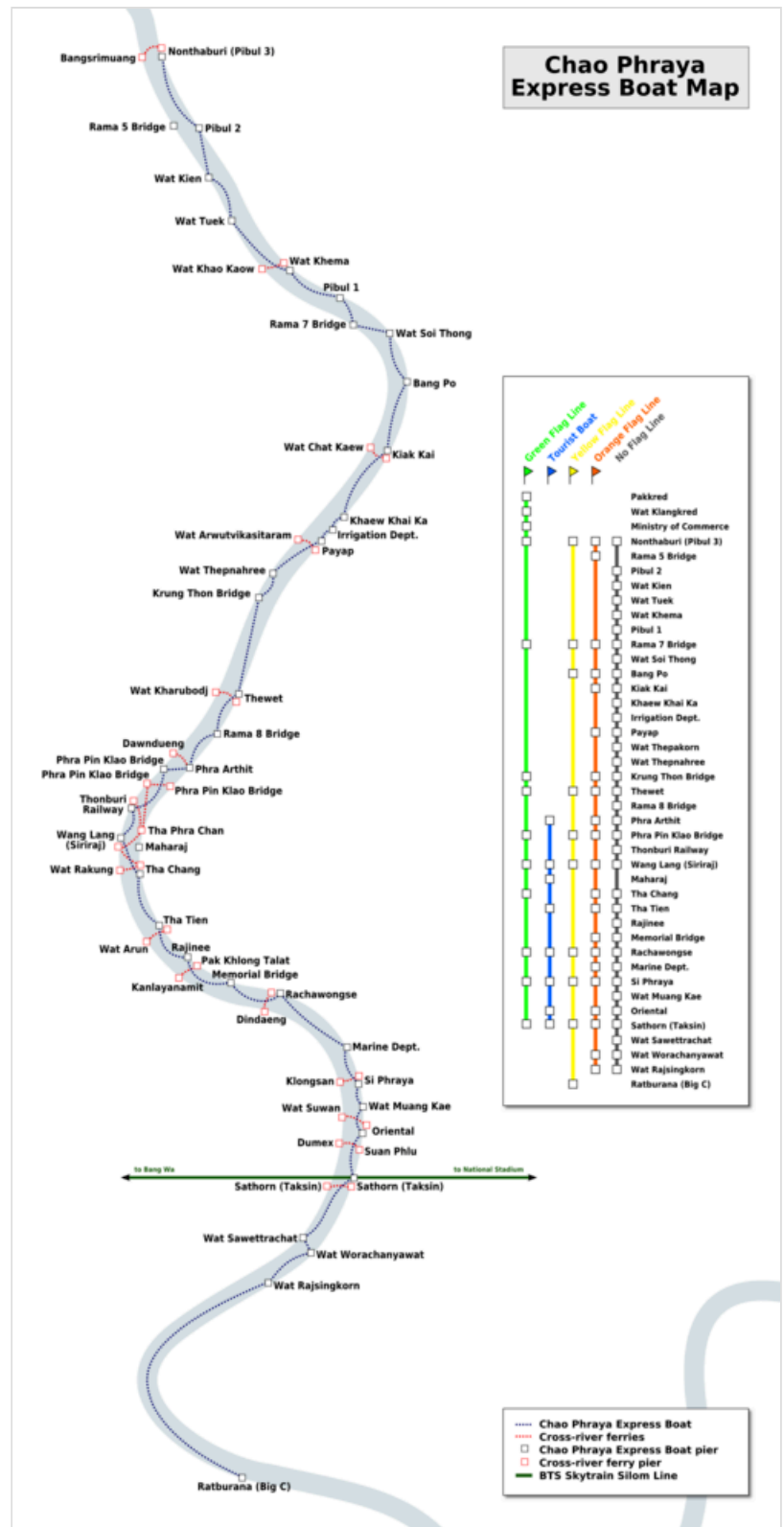
The different boat lines are indicated by the colour of the triangular pennant at the end of the boat. These flags can be confusing; don't think the yellow king's flag corresponds to the yellow line flag!

- The **orange flag line** (14 baht, every day 06:00-19:00) is your best bet, as it covers the major tourist areas and is fairly quick. However, it does not stop at every pier unlike the:
- Basic "**no flag**" line (8, 10 or 12 baht) which is fairly slow and runs only during rush hours (M–F 06:45–07:30 and M–F 16:00–16:30).
- It is better to avoid the faster **yellow flag** line (M–F 06:15–08:10 and M–F 15:30–18:05) since it skips many popular attractions including Khao San Road, the Grand Palace and Wat Pho.
- The **green flag** line (10, 12, 19 or 31 baht, M–F 06:10–08:10 and M–F 16:05–18:05) skips many piers but its Pakkred terminus is the closest pier to **Ko Kret** if you want to spend a weekday there.

In addition to the workaday express boats, there is a **blue flagged Tourist Boat** which stops at a small subset of piers, offers commentary in English and offers a day pass and single ride tickets. The boats are slightly more comfortable and may be worth considering if you want to cruise up and down the most important tourist sights. They only operate once per 30 min and stop running by 15:00. The price is 40 baht (single journey, 150 baht for one day pass). Be careful as staff may tell that the (cheaper) orange flag regular boat is not coming for quite a while (as they are aggressively touting for business), but sometimes this is not the truth. If you want the tourist experience with guide and (very) loud speaker commentary, often unintelligible, then this is the one for you. However, be aware that you are fully entitled to enter the public piers (the ones with the blue lettering on white background with pier numbers on them) and take whichever express boat you want since no ticket is needed before boarding.

The signposting of the piers is quite clear, with numbered piers and English route maps. **Sathorn (Taksin)** pier has been dubbed "Central" station, as it offers a quick interchange to Saphan Taksin BTS Station. The boats run every 5–20 min from sunrise to sunset (roughly from 06:00–19:00), so ignore any river taxi touts who try to convince you otherwise. Beware of pier closures: in particular, as of 2022 **Tha Tien** pier next to Wat Pho has been closed for several years now for major upgrading works, requiring visitors to alight at Wat Arun and take another ferry across.

Many piers are also served by cross-river ferries. These are particularly useful for reaching **Wat Arun** or the many piers at the Thonburi side of the river. Cross-river ferries run around every 10 min and only cost 4.5 baht. Pay at the kiosk on the pier and then walk through the turnstile.



Chao Phraya Express Boat Map



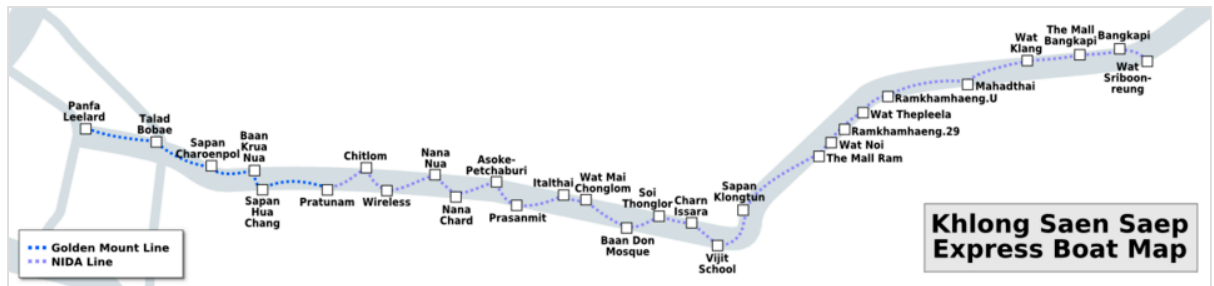
## Saen Saep Express Boat

The **Saen Saep Express Boat** serves the long Saen Saep Canal, one of the remaining canals (*khlong*) that used to flow through Bangkok. Mostly used by locals to commute to work, the service is cheap and you get to see the "backside" of the neighbourhoods, so to speak. Also, It is immune to Bangkok's notorious traffic jams. The total distance is 18 km (11 mi), and the service operates from 05:30-20:30.



Saen Saep Express Boats

They  
are



Saen Saep Express Boat Map

comparatively safe — just watch your step when boarding and disembarking as they don't stop at the pier for long and do not let the dirty water get into your eyes. To prevent splashes, the boats are equipped with little curtains that you can raise by pulling on a string, but they have to be lowered at every stop so people can clamber on board. Pay the fare to the fearless helmet-wearing ticket collectors who clamber around on the outside of the boat, ducking at bridges, as it barrels down the canal. Press the green 'bell' button if you want to get off at the next pier, else the boat might just skip it. The piers now even have (tiny) signs in English, with the exception of **The Mall Bangkapi** pier, and it's not obvious that you're at the mall when you get off the boat!

The canal runs parallel to Phetchaburi Road, and provides the easiest access from the Golden Mount in Rattanakosin (and nearby Khao San Road) to Siam Square and Pratunam. This line is aptly called the **Golden Mount Line** and runs from **Panfa Leelard** pier to **Pratunam** pier. If you want to continue your journey beyond Pratunam, passengers have to change boats there. The **NIDA Line** starts at Pratunam and heads east to Sukhumvit and Ramkhamhaeng. Hold on to your ticket.

## River taxi

For trips outside set routes, you can hire a **long-tail river taxi** at any major pier. These are fairly expensive, but with some haggling they may be suitable for small groups. To circumvent the mafia-like touts who attempt to get a large cut for every ride, agree for the price of the shortest possible ride (30 min), then negotiate directly with the captain when on board.

## By bus

**Local buses**, operated by the **Bangkok Mass Transit Authority** (<http://www.bmta.co.th/?q=en/home>) (องค์การขนส่งมวลชนกรุงเทพ). aka **BMTA** (ขสมก), are the cheapest but also the most challenging way of getting around. There is a bewildering plethora of routes, usually marked only in Thai. Even locals have a hard time with these, but at least they can call the **1348**



**Bus Route Hotline**, which is in Thai only. Bus stops list only the bus numbers that stop there and nothing more. They are also subject to Bangkok's notorious traffic, often terribly crowded, and many are not air-conditioned. If you want to get somewhere quickly and are not prepared to get lost, the buses should be avoided: remember that taxis are cheaper than most local buses in the West. However, they make for a good adventure if you're not in a rush and you don't mind being the centre of attention.



A BMTA ordinary bus



There is the Viabus app (for Android (<https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.indyzalab.transitia&hl=en>) and IOS (<https://apps.apple.com/th/app/viabus/id1074208600>)) which really helps finding your way around the bus system. In the app you can search for bus stops and bus routes, navigate and even GPS track busses. Also the app is available in English and you can select stops on a map.

Otherwise, for those staying in Khao San Road where buses are the only practical means of public transport, the only free resource for decrypting bus routes is the official BMTA website. It has up-to-date if slightly incomplete listings of bus routes in English, but no maps. You can also ask your guest house about which buses to take if you're going to a particular destination. As a printed reference, the money spent on the *Bangkok Bus Map* by Roadway is a good investment if you're going to travel by bus more than once.

The hierarchy of Bangkok's buses from cheapest to best can be ranked as follows:

- **Red bus**, 8 baht flat fare. Spacious and fan-cooled (in theory). Unlike other buses, some of these run through the night (1.50 baht surcharge). These buses are BMTA-run.
- **White/blue/orange bus**, 10 baht flat fare. Exactly the same as the red buses, but cost two baht more. These buses are owned by private entities operated in conjunction with BMTA.
- **Blue/yellow and cream/blue air-con**, 12 baht for the first 8 km (5 mi), up to 20 baht max. These buses are quite comfy. The blue/yellow striped buses are privately owned while the blue/cream buses are BMTA-owned.
- **White/Orange air-con (Euro II)**. 13 baht for the first few km, up to 25 baht max. These are all BMTA-run, newer, and more comfortable.
- **Blue air-con (NGV)**, 15 baht for the first few km, up to 25 baht max. These are run by both private companies and the BMTA, and are the newest and most comfortable buses.

BMTA-owned buses accept contactless payment, using the same fare scheme as normal tickets. The conductor will bring you a machine for you to scan your card. BMTA also offers pre-paid cards, monthly and weekly tickets using the same system. Weekly tickets cost 135 baht for red buses only and 270 baht for all buses. Monthly tickets cost 270 baht for red buses only and 540 baht for all buses.

Buses stop only when needed, so wave them down (arm out, palm down) when you see one barreling your way. Although drivers are only meant to stop at bus stops, some may pick up and drop off passengers elsewhere. Once on board, pay the roaming collector after you board and keep the ticket, as there can be occasional spot-checks. Press the signal buzzer, usually near the door, when you want to get off.



Two further pitfalls are that buses of the same number may run slightly different routes depending on the colour, and there are also express services (mostly indicated by yellow signs) that skip some stops and may take the expressway.

Airport buses allow luggage but regular buses do not. Enforcement of this rule varies.

## By taxi

### Rideshare taxi

The main ride sharing company operating in Bangkok is **Grab** (<https://www.grab.com/th/en/>), which can also be used to book taxis. With predictable fares and easy English address entry, Grab is a convenient way to avoid both language barriers and possible taxi scams, although during surge periods fares may be higher. That said, good luck getting a taxi to use the meter if caught in a rainstorm late at night. You also have the option pay your driver in cash. Just like the case with taxis, you have to pay the cost of any tolls when using a ride share service at the toll booth.

### Metered taxi

Metered taxis are a quick and comfortable way to get around town, at least if the traffic is flowing your way, but be warned that Bangkok taxi drivers are notorious for finding ways to run up the fare; insist that the meter is used, and if the driver claims that your destination is closed, if they don't know your destination, or if you're being taken elsewhere, just get out of the taxi. All taxis are now metered and air-conditioned. There are no surcharges (except from the airport), even at night; don't believe drivers who try to tell you otherwise. A red sign on the front window, if lit, means that the taxi is available.



A corporate metered taxi



When the meter is switched on you will see a red number indicating the hailing fee somewhere on the dashboard or between the driver and you. Be sure to check for this at the start of the ride, as many drivers will "forget" to start the meter in order to overcharge you at the end of your trip. Most will start the meter when asked politely to do so (*meter na khrap* if you're male and *meter na kha* if you're female); if the driver refuses to use the meter after a couple of attempts, simply exit the taxi.

Avoid taxis parked outside hotels or major tourist attractions; they are mostly there in the hope of greatly overcharging tourists, or getting commissions from businesses where they take you. Near major tourist districts like Khao San or Patpong, especially late at night, you will need to walk a block away to catch an honest driver. Sometimes your best bet is to walk to the road and catch an unoccupied metered taxi in motion (easier than it sounds, as Bangkok traffic tends to crawl the majority of the time, and one car out of four is a taxi), or go to a taxi stand where you see many locals queueing. Be smart and give your money to honest drivers, not cheats and touts. The only reason why they get away with this so frequently is that foreign tourists let them.

Be sure to either know the correct pronunciation of your destination, or have it written in Thai, as taxi drivers in Bangkok are notoriously bad at reading maps, and most drivers speak limited English. Most hotels and guest houses will happily write out addresses in Thai for you. It is often difficult to properly pronounce addresses in Thai and even if most drivers will recognise the names of tourist hot spots even if grossly mispronounced, you may be out of luck. If your mobile phone works in Thailand, it is sometimes useful to call your hotel and ask the staff to speak to your driver in Thai. In addition, try to get your hotel's business card to show the taxi driver in case you get lost.



Green and yellow taxis like this are owner-operated. 

The very common yellow-green taxis are ones to avoid. They are owner-operated and of highly variable quality, and occasionally have rigged meters. All other colours belong to large taxi companies, which usually enforce their standards better.

On some routes, the driver will ask if the *tollway* should be used — this will usually save a lot of time. You have to pay the cost at the toll booth (not in advance and not at the end of the journey). Watch how much the driver really pays, as many try to keep the change.

When getting out, try to have small bills (100 baht or less) or expect problems with change. Tips are not necessary, but are certainly welcome if you're happy about the service; most local passengers will round up or leave any coin change as tip.

### Tuk-tuk taxi

What would Bangkok be without the much-loathed, much-loved **tuk-tuks**? You'll know them when you hear them, and you'll hate them when you smell them — these three-wheeled contraptions blaze around Bangkok leaving a black cloud of smog in their wake. For anything more than a 5-10 min jaunt or just the experience, they really are not worth the price — and, if you let them get away with it, the price will usually be 4 or 5 times what it should be anyway (which, for Thais, is around 30% less than the equivalent metered taxi fare).



Tuk-tuks on the prowl 

On the other hand, you can sometimes ride for free if you agree to visit touristy clothing or jewellery shops (which give the tuk-tuk driver fuel coupons and commissions for bringing customers). The shops' salespeople are pushy, and try to scam you with bad quality suits or "gems" that in fact are worthless pieces of cut glass. But usually you are free to leave after 5-10 min of browsing. Visitors should beware though, sometimes one stop can turn in to three, and tuk-tuk drivers may not be interested in taking you where you need to go once they have their fuel coupons. Also, with Bangkok's densely congested traffic it is sure to waste hours of your time, if not the whole day.

If you still want to try the tuk-tuk, always hail a moving tuk-tuk from the main road. At tourist spots, these tuk-tuk drivers lie in waiting to disrupt your travels plans. Always **agree on a price** before entering the tuk-tuk. Also be crystal clear about your intended destination. If they claim that your intended destination is closed for the day, and offer to take you to other nearby tourist spots, insist on your destination or get out. If you're an all-male party, tuk-tuk drivers sometimes will just ignore your destination completely and start driving you to some brothel ("beautiful girls"). Insist continually and forcefully on going only to your destination; or take a metered taxi instead.



Riding a tuk-tuk in Bangkok

### Motorbike taxi

When traffic slows to a crawl and there are no mass-transit alternatives for your destination, by far the fastest mode of transport is a **motorbike taxi** ( วินมอเตอร์ไซด์ *win motosai*). They typically wear colourful fluorescent yellow-orange vests and wait for passengers at busy places. Prices should be agreed in advance.

For the adrenaline junkie, a wild motosai ride can provide a fantastic rush. Imagine weaving through rows of stopped vehicles at 50 km/h (30 mi/h) with mere centimetres to spare on each side, dodging pedestrians, other motorbikes, tuk-tuks, stray dogs and the occasional elephant while the driver blithely ignores all traffic laws and even some laws of physics. Now do the same while facing backwards on the bike and balancing a large television on your lap, and then you can qualify as a local — though you might die in the process. Imagine your loved ones arranging to ship your dead body home from Bangkok because you took a dangerous risk you were warned not to. **Motorcycle accidents are brutally common**, and transportation of this sort is inherently hazardous. Be aware of the risk before using motorcycle taxis.



A Bangkok motorcycle taxi operator

The overwhelming majority of motorcycle taxis do not travel long distances, but simply shuttle up and down long sois (side-streets) not serviced by other transport for a fixed fare. These are marginally less dangerous, especially if travel with the flow on a one-way street.

The law requires that both driver and passenger must wear a helmet. It is the driver's responsibility to provide you with one, so if you are stopped by police, any fine is also the driver's responsibility. However the provision of helmets is far from universal. A helmet should be provided when hiring a motorbike or moped, and two if there are two of you. When riding, keep a firm grasp on the seat handle and watch out for your knees.



## By car

Bangkok is notorious for its massive traffic jams, and rightly so. In addition, traffic is chaotic and motorcyclists seemingly suicidal. Therefore, most tourists consider driving in Bangkok a nightmare, and it is recommended that you stick to public transport. However, the proliferation of massive shopping malls means that there are now places to park if you must drive into town, albeit at a high cost. Smartphones with GPS and navigation apps with voice directions make it easier to find your way.

## By foot

Many of Bangkok's main attractions are within 5 km (3.1 mi) from Siam Square. Walking long distances in hot weather along busy streets can be exhausting, but is a good way to get to see the city up close. Just drink plenty of water and watch out for uneven surfaces and motorcyclists. Food leftovers and the occasional surprises left by stray animals are other reasons to look where you're going. Bangkok residents almost instinctively avoid stepping on manhole covers because people have fallen into sewers through rotten ones. Women carry their handbags on the side away from the road to discourage bag snatchers on motorbikes.

Be careful when crossing the road, even if you have a green light. Turning left at a red light is legal by default and drivers turn without indicators and without yielding to pedestrians. Drivers will not stop or slow down at crosswalks without traffic lights. When waiting to cross at major intersections with rounded corners, stand well away from the road, as turning motorcyclists may lean over the curb in order to squeeze past other vehicles. Always use pedestrian overpasses when available; Bangkok stray dogs are smart enough to use them.

Expect to be accosted by taxi and tuk-tuk drivers and hustlers demanding to know where you're going, insisting that there is nothing to see ahead, and attempting to usher you to various businesses. Most will quickly move on to their next mark if ignored or firmly dismissed.

If you are weighed down by a large backpack and would like to leave it in a locker, do check out the automated lockers (<https://www.lockbox-th.com/>) provided near several major metro stations. The charges vary based on size of the locker. A medium-sized locker can take two backpacks and will cost about 30 Baht an hour.

## See

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*Individual listings can be found in Bangkok's district articles*



An automated locker system near Chatuchak park

Most of Bangkok's sights are concentrated on the island of Rattanakosin, often referred to as the "Old City". Out of Bangkok's hundreds of temples, the **Grand Palace**, **Wat Pho** and **Wat Arun** usually make up the top 3. The Grand Palace has an immense size, so expect to spend at least a full morning or afternoon there. Within the palace grounds is **Wat Phra Kaew**, the most sacred Buddhist temple of Thailand. Unlike other temples, it is not one building, nor are there

living spaces for monks. Instead, it is a collection of highly decorated holy buildings and monuments. One of its buildings houses the **Emerald Buddha**, and while you might not expect it from its size, it is the most sacred Buddha image in Thailand.

Nearby is **Wat Pho**, home to the world's largest reclining Buddha image and a famed massage school. Take the ferry across the Chao Phraya River to Thonburi for the outstanding **Wat Arun**. The main structure is about 60 to 88 m high and it is surrounded by four smaller prangs. It is one of Thailand's most picturesque temples, and is engraved on the inner part of all ten baht coins. It is so recognisable that it even became the logo of the Tourism Authority of Thailand (TAT). If you climb it, and look closely, you will see that it is beautifully decorated with colourful broken Chinese porcelain pieces. Heading back to Rattanakosin, there are many other major temples you could visit, including the **Golden Mount**, **Wat Suthat** and **Wat Ratchanaddaram**.

Don't throw away the entry ticket of the Grand Palace, as it gives free entry to the **Bang Pa-In Palace** in Bang Pa-In (and not anymore to the Dusit Palace which has been closed to the public since 2017). There are many museums in Bangkok showing traditional Thai-style residences. Many visitors take a tour through **Jim Thompson's House**, the CIA-operative's mansion assembled by combining six traditional Thai-style houses near Siam Square. **Ban Kamthieng** in Sukhumvit, **M.R. Kukrit's Heritage Home** in Silom and the **Suan Pakkad Palace** in Phahonyothin are not quite as impressive, but still make for a nice experience. Rattanakosin's museums are mostly dedicated to history and culture, including the **National Museum** (about Thai history and archaeological remains), the **Museum of Siam**, **Rattanakosin Museum** (which offers two guided tours with interactive displays regarding the history of old and modern Thai life), and the **King Prajadhipok Museum**. Bangkok has a small, but vocal art community, and you might want to visit the **National Gallery** or **The Queen's Gallery**, or one of the numerous smaller galleries spread over the city. Siam Square features the **Bangkok Art and Culture Centre** which has temporary art exhibitions throughout the year.

**Lumphini Park** in Silom is the largest park in central Bangkok, and a good way to escape the fumes. Backpackers around Khao San Road can head for **Santichaiprakarn Park**, a small but fun park along the Chao Phraya River with a breezy atmosphere, usually with locals juggling or practicing tricks. It is built around the 18th-century **Phra Sumen Fort** with a nice view on the modern Rama VIII cable-stayed bridge. Zoos and animal farms are some of the more popular tourist attractions in Bangkok, but before visiting, please be aware that animal welfare in Thailand is not strictly regulated. Poor living conditions of the animals and inadequate veterinary care are examples of the sad mistreatment of the animal population. You can't go wrong at the **Queen Saovabha Institute Snake Farm** in Silom, as the staff takes good care of their snakes and they have a job of informing the public about the risks associated with them. Another nice family attraction is **Siam Ocean World** in Siam Square. It has a steep price tag, but at least you get to see the largest aquarium in Southeast Asia. Great views of Bangkok from above open up from the Mahanakhon skyscraper's observation deck (<https://mahanakhon-bangkok.com>).

## "Colonial" architecture

Although Thailand was never colonised, due to the desire of Kings Rama IV (1804-1868) and Rama V (1868-1910) to modernise Thailand based on Western models, visitors might be surprised to find that Bangkok has no shortage of European-style buildings that would not be out



of place in other Southeast Asian capitals. While other Southeast Asian capitals tend to be dominated by buildings of a specific architectural style depending on their colonial history (e.g., French in Hanoi, British in Yangon), Bangkok has a mix of buildings with architectural styles from different parts of Europe. For instance, **Hua Lamphong Railway Station**, Bangkok's main railway station, was designed by Italian architects and hence built in an Italian neo-Renaissance style. Other notable European-style buildings include the Italian Old Customs House, the Danish East Asiatic Company headquarters, and the Art Deco-style General Post Office. One of the most interesting European-influenced buildings is the **Chakri Maha Prasat Hall** in the Grand Palace, which was built mostly in an Italian neoclassical style, but with a traditional Thai roof. The greatest concentration of European buildings can be found in Rattanakosin and Yaowarat.

## Itineraries

- [One day in Bangkok](#) — if you have just one day to spare and want to catch a feel for the city
- [Rattanakosin Tour](#) — a quick tour along Bangkok's famed historic district
- [Yaowarat and Phahurat Tour](#) — a full-day walking tour through this multicultural district

## Do

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*Individual listings can be found in Bangkok's [district](#) articles*

## Festivals

All of Thailand's major festivals are celebrated in Bangkok. **New Year** is celebrated three times. There's the new year following the Gregorian calendar at January 1, celebrated with a huge fireworks display at [Ratchaprasong intersection](#). Then there's **Chinese New Year** in January or February, with grandiose and colourful Chinese lion and dragon processions in [Yaowarat](#). Finally, the water festivities of **Songkran** celebrate the traditional Thai New Year in the middle of April. [Khao San Road](#) degenerates into a war zone as *farangs* and locals duke it out with super soakers. More respectable celebrations are held at Sanam Luang, where the revered Phra Phuttha Sihing image is displayed and bathed by devotees, and at the Wisut Kasat intersection, where a Miss Songkran beauty contest is held and accompanied by merit-making and entertainment.



Launching a *krathong* down a pond



During the **Royal Ploughing Ceremony** in May, farmers believe that an ancient Brahman ritual, conducted at Sanam Luang, is able to forecast whether the coming growing season will be bountiful or not. The event dates back to the Sukhothai Kingdom and was re-introduced in 1960 by King Bhumibol Adulyadej. It is considered the official commencement of the rice-growing season (and the rainy season). Nowadays, the ceremony is conducted by King Maha Vajiralongkorn. **Loi Krathong** (ลอยกระทง), the Festival of Lights, usually takes place in November. *Krathongs* are floating rafts made from lotus flowers and banana leaves with a

lighted candle and incense on top. On the night of the full moon, Thais send their *krathong* down a river, canal or pond, and the owner's bad luck carries away along with it insuring a fresh start. Celebrations take place all over town with parades, concerts and beauty pageants. Loi Krathong coincides with the Lanna festival **Yi Peng** (ยี่เป็ง). At this festival, a multitude of Lanna-style paper lanterns are launched into the air. Lumpini Park is the best place to launch a krathong down the pond or to launch a paper lantern into the sky.

The **Trooping of the Colours** in early December is an impressive annual event, held in the Royal Plaza near the equestrian statue of King Rama V in Dusit. Dressed in colourful uniforms, amid much pomp and ceremony, members of the elite Royal Guards swear allegiance to the King and march past members of the Royal Family. December 5 is **Father's Day**, the former King's birthday, and Ratchadamri Road and the Grand Palace are elaborately decorated and illuminated.

## Canals

Until the late 19th century, Bangkok (just like Ayutthaya) was known as "Venice of the East". Most people lived near or on the water and an intricate network of canals (*khlong*) was the primary mode of transport for the city's inhabitants. Most canals have since been paved over, but plenty of them remain and some still function as transport routes as of this day. The traditional canal-side way of life has almost vanished, but as Thonburi was largely undeveloped until the 20th century, there is still some authenticity to be found. Floating markets had completely disappeared by the 20th century, but have been reinstated for tourism purposes and are a fun visit.

You can see the Chao Phraya River and the backwaters of the city by **canal tour**. Most of these boat trips start at the eastern bank of the Chao Phraya and then ply through the backwaters of Thonburi taking in Wat Arun, the Royal Barges National Museum, a floating market and some other minor attractions. More information about these canal tours can be found in the Thonburi article. At 1,000 baht or more, they are quite expensive. You can also negotiate a price with individual boat drivers. Damnoen Saduak is a floating market that often appears in tourist brochures of Bangkok, but in practice it is 109 km (68 mi) west of Bangkok and has to be visited by bus from the Southern Bus Terminal.

Probably just as fun is to take the public **express boat** along the Chao Phraya River. You can get off anywhere between the Thewet and Sathorn (Taksin) piers as there are many things to see in all of these neighbourhoods. You can even take the express boat all the way north to Nonthaburi in the morning, enjoy the afternoon in this laid-back traditional urban town, and take the boat back around rush hour. Another option is to get on one of the free **hotel shuttle boats** at Sathorn (Taksin) pier and have a bite at one of the associated cafés. In the evenings, Asiatique has a free shuttle boat from Sathorn (Taksin) pier to the new shopping centre downriver. A good place to see beautiful sunsets over the river.

## Pampering

**Spas**, traditionally, were towns where public baths, hospitals or hotels were built on top of mineral springs so that people could come and make use of the healing properties found in the water and its mud for medical purposes. These days, a spa doesn't have to be a town built on

natural thermal springs. It can be a place anywhere that anyone can go to, to relax in tranquil surroundings with a variety of treatment administered to recontour and rejuvenate the body and mind.

Spas were unheard of until the 1990s, but now Bangkok is one of the highest ranking spa destinations in the world with an amazing array of treatments. All self-respecting luxury hotels in Bangkok have a spa that at least offers a traditional Thai massage. Prices are exorbitant, but they offer some of the best treatments in the city. Well-regarded spas at exceptionally high rates are given at the splurge hotels in Silom; particularly the spa at the Dusit Thani Hotel stands out. Independent spas offer much the same experience, but offer much more competitive rates. Figure around 1,000 baht/hr for most treatments.



Thai massage in Bangkok

The ubiquitous little massage shops found on every street corner offer good value, particularly around Khao San Road and Sukhumvit. Legitimate massage shops typically charge 250–400 baht for a two-hour massage and will often have therapists working on customers' feet in public view at the entrance. Be aware that not all establishments advertising massage actually offer it — if the shopfront looks more like a bar than a clinic and staff are actively soliciting passersby, it's probably not the kind of massage you're looking for.

## Muay Thai

Muay Thai is both a combat sport and a means of self-defence. Contestants are allowed to use almost any part of the body for fighting: feet, elbows, legs, knees and shoulders. There are two venues in Bangkok to see this sport in action: **Lumpinee Boxing Stadium** in Silom and **Ratchadamnoen Stadium** in Rattanakosin. Sessions can take the whole evening and it's not that bad if you come in slightly late as the more interesting fights tend to happen at the end. The playing of traditional music during the bouts is enjoyable as well. A downer is the steep 1,000–2,000 baht entry fee for foreigners. Thais chip in for 100 baht or less.

If you want to see Muay Thai for free, go to the **MBK Fight Night** outside MBK Center near Siam Square. Fights take place the last Wednesday evening of each month (starts at 18:00, lasts until around 21:00). Another option is to walk to the end of Soi Rambuttri into an alley known as Trok Kasap (near Khao San Road). Foreigners are getting classes in Muay Thai out in the open there, and many tourists generally sit on a bench in front of it to look at the action. Besides looking, this is an excellent place to do some Muay Thai yourself.

## Cycling

Bicycles can be rented for free in Rattanakosin, but cyclists are officially not allowed to leave the set route along the island. Even when following the route, it's still not for the faint of heart.

If renting your own bicycle, avoid the main roads and cycle through the vast system of small streets and alleys. You can cycle through the backstreets of Yaowarat, but you might want to think twice before making a turn. You can also experience life in Bangkok's countryside by cycling through green paddy fields, orchid farms and lotus fields. *Bang Kachao*, in brochures often referred to as the "Bangkok Jungle", is Bangkok's last green frontier. It's a semi-island across the river from Bangkok with few cars and buildings, and a great destination for cycling.

Cyclists are treated as pedestrians, so you can use your bicycle to explore parks, temple complexes, markets and the more quiet residential areas in eastern Bangkok. In more crowded places you can cycle on the pavement. Exploring by bicycle has all the advantages of going by foot, combined with a much greater travel radius and a cooling breeze. Cycling is the best way to discover the city up close, but as there are safety issues involved, you need some insider knowledge on where to cycle. Because of this, many opt for a bicycle tour organised by an operator.

- **Bangkok Biking** (<http://www.bangkokbiking.com>), Baan Sri Kung 350/123, Soi 71, Rama III Rd, ☎ +66 2-285 3955. Bicycle tours in small groups to and through unseen parts of Bangkok. Mostly free of traffic. A fun excursion for the whole family. 950-2,400 baht.
- **Co van Kessel** (<http://www.covankessel.com/>), ☎ +66 2 639-7351. Many cycling tours through Bangkok, taking in Chinatown, the canals of Thonburi, the "Bangkok Jungle" and many other places in between. 950-1,950 baht.
- **Follow Me Bicycle Tours** (<http://www.followmebiketour.com/>), 126 Sathorn Tai Rd, ☎ +66 2 286-5891. Half-day bicycle tours through Bangkok's residential streets. Included in the price is a fish spa and a barbecue meal after the tour. 1,000 baht.
- **Grasshopper Adventures** (<http://www.grasshopperadventures.com/>), 57 Ratchadamnoen Klang Rd (*near the Democracy Monument, right around the corner from Khao San Rd*), ☎ +66 2 280-0832, [journeys@grasshopperadventures.com](mailto:journeys@grasshopperadventures.com) (<mailto:journeys@grasshopperadventures.com>). Tours through the historic Rattanakosin district of Bangkok, to the outskirts of Bangkok and one that takes place at night. 1,000-1,600 baht.
- **SpiceRoads** (<http://spiceroads.com>), 45 Soi Pannee, Pridi Banomyong Soi 26, Sukhumvit Soi 71, ☎ +66 2 381-7490. Many one and multi-day cycling trips in and around Bangkok. There are trips to the Bangkok Jungle, Ko Kret, Yaowarat, and Thonburi. 2,950 baht.
- **1 Go Bangkok Tours** (<http://www.gobangkoktours.com>), 51 Charoen Krung, Soi 44, Bang Rak (*BTS Saphan Taksin exit 1, 3 min walk*), ☎ +66 2-630 7563, fax: +66 2-630 7563, [info@gobangkoktours.com](mailto:info@gobangkoktours.com) (<mailto:info@gobangkoktours.com>). Bicycle tours, some of which are GPS-guided, and bicycle rentals. Small groups, max 6. Safe and fun. 350-1,500 baht.

## Theatre

The **Aksra Theatre** in the King Power Complex Building in Pratunam holds spectacular shows that are a combination of Thai traditional puppet shows, orchestral performances and classical dances. The Joe Louis Theatre in the Asiatique is completely dedicated to the art of operating Hun Lakhon Lek puppets. One segment has the puppets interact with audience members, which is a fun activity with children. Both Aksra and Joe Louis feature stories taken from the Ramayana epic.

Of a completely different nature are Bangkok's famous transvestite shows. These cabarets generally take about 2 hours, and besides singing, dancing, glamour and costumes, there's also has some comedy thrown in. The most famous of these is the **Calypso Cabaret** at Ratchathewi intersection with two sessions every evening at the Asia Hotel. An alternative is **Mambo**



**Cabaret**, once in Sukhumvit but now at a new location far off the tourist path in Yan Nawa. Three shows are given each evening. Always book these shows a couple of days in advance as they usually sell out.

## Entertainment

Bangkok is a great place to go to the **cinema**. Compared to Western countries, the cost of a ticket is a complete bargain at around 120 baht. Most cinemas have world-class standards and show the latest Hollywood and Thai releases. They are up to par with the latest technological innovations in the film industry, so expect to wear 3D glasses for some of the latest Hollywood releases. You can also visit the IMAX Theatre in Siam Paragon. Thai films can be seen by foreigners as they are usually shown with English subtitles. For non-mainstream cinema, House Samyan (in Samyan Mitrtown shopping mall) and APEX (in Siam Square) offer art films with English subtitles.

For other means of entertainment, Ratchadaphisek is a newly created entertainment paradise. Its **bowling centres** are of a superb standard with some of them resembling the interior of a nightclub. Dance while you play in style. Private karaoke lounges are usually connected to these bowling centres and are available at major hotels. There's even an ice skating rink and a top-class go-kart track in this district. As Ratchadaphisek is mostly aimed at locals, you might want to go to similar venues in Siam Square or Sukhumvit. **Horse races** are held on Sundays at two alternate turf clubs: the Royal Turf Club of Thailand in Dusit and the Royal Bangkok Sports Club on Henri Dunant Road near Siam Square.

## Aerobics dance

Bangkok is a good place for aerobics dancing. Many places in Bangkok, for example, supermarkets or public parks, offer free outdoor aerobics classes. These classes usually start in the morning at 06:00 or in the evening at 18:00, and the session would last for one hour. Wear appropriate clothing. These classes don't require Thai language skill because instructor rarely uses verbal cues. Aside from exercising you can also meet the community of local people and foreigners.

For supermarkets, you can expect to find classes in Lotus or Big C. They only have classes in the evening, and are usually held in or nearby the parking areas. For public parks, there are many places but the most famous one is in the Lumphini park in Silom district. They have classes in the morning and in the evening at the ceremonial gate.

## Learn

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Learning opportunities are abundant in Bangkok. Thai cuisine is a favourite of many, and plenty of **cooking schools** provide half-day classes that provide a nice break from the day-to-day sightseeing monotony. Silom and Khao San Road particularly have some of the better-known Thai cooking schools.

**Meditation**, the essence of 'pure' Buddhism, can be practised at any temple in Thailand. In addition, there are centres in Bangkok that cater specifically to foreigners wishing to learn and practise. The International Buddhist Meditation Centre inside Wat Mahathat in Rattanakosin

provides free meditation classes three times a day. If you can understand Thai well enough, you may wish to go on your own retreat at a quiet temple on the outskirts of Bangkok. To pay for your stay, it is appreciated that you assist the resident monks on their morning alms rounds.

The Wat Pho temple in Rattanakosin offers well-regarded **Thai massage** courses. They are used to conducting classes in English.

## Universities

- **1 Chulalongkorn University (<https://www.chula.ac.th/>)**. The oldest and most prestigious institute of higher education in Thailand.
- **2 National Institute of Development Administration (<http://www.nida.ac.th>)**. The only university in Thailand that focuses on business education. (updated Dec 2023 | )
- **3 Assumption University (<https://www.au.edu/>)**. Thailand's most prestigious private Catholic university. (updated Dec 2023 | )
- **4 Ramkhamhaeng University (<http://www.ru.ac.th>)**. Thailand's largest public university. (updated Dec 2023 | )

## Buy

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### Money

Getting cash in Bangkok is relatively easy, see below. Also, credit cards are widely accepted at larger establishments.

#### Cash advance

You can avoid expensive ATM withdrawals or carrying a lot of cash for currency exchange by going to a bank branch (mostly Bangkok Bank) and doing cash advance with your credit card and passport.

#### Currency exchange

**Superrich Thailand (<http://www.superrichthailand.com/>)** ("Superrich Green" and **Superrich 1965 (<https://www.superrich1965.com/>)** ("Superrich Orange") are two competing currency exchange change that offer decent rates of exchange, with their respective head offices in Pathum Wan (within walking distance of Central World, both across the street from each other) usually offering better rates than their other branches.

The two most competitive money changers are at Phaya Thai station, the end of the Airport Rail Link, right outside the ticket area near the ticket vending machines. They are open from 10:00. They have rates 0.1–0.2% (*markup*) off the interbank exchange rates for all major currencies, i.e. you can change money directly here when you arrive and leave Thailand via Bangkok airport (Template:BKK). A great alternative to the overly expensive ATM withdrawals.

#### ATMs

ATMs are spread all over the city, especially in central areas. All ATMs charge a commission for using foreign cards at ATMs of at least 220 baht.

## Shopping

*Individual listings can be found in Bangkok's district articles*

Dump a teenager in Siam Square with a few thousand baht and she'll stay occupied for the rest of the week! Siam Square is *the* place to shop in Bangkok; the small sois of Siam Square have dozens of small designer boutiques. **MBK Center** and **Siam Center** are the most popular shopping malls, as they sell fashion well below Western rates. **Siam Paragon**, **EmQuartier** in Sukhumvit, **ICONSIAM** in Khlong San, **Central Embassy** in Phloen Chit and the shopping plazas at Ratchaprasong feel even larger, but are much quieter, as most local Thais cannot afford the Guccis and Louis Vuittons on sale there. Ladies will also feel well at home in the **Emporium** next to EmQuartier.

Just take a few steps out of your hotel and Bangkok feels like a huge street market. Sukhumvit has the usual souvenirs, T-shirts and other tacky tourist junk. Browsing Khao San Road's roadside stalls is particularly good for clothing and accessories, many of them for a bargain. While many of these stalls still cater to the traditional hippie crowd, they have been slowly gentrifying to appeal to a broader audience. The nearby **Banglamphu Market** sells cheap knock-offs of everything, just like the night markets in Silom and Rattanakosin.

In the weekends, the **Chatuchak Weekend Market** in Phahonyothin is a must as its 8,000 stalls together form the largest market in Southeast Asia. Shoppers can buy just about everything from clothing to potted plants and everything in between — it is a paradise for browsers and bargain-hunters alike. A weekday alternative is Pratunam, one of the city's renowned garment markets. Clothes shopping here goes on wholesale, and you're even cheaper off if you buy in bulk. At **Pantip Plaza** you can buy computer-related stuff from branded laptops to pirated DVDs.

Yaowarat and Phahurat give a more authentic experience, although many stores sell the cheap teen accessories found elsewhere as well. Just sitting at a plastic chair and watching daily commerce evolve is a fun activity in itself. Phahurat is the best destination for fabrics, available in all colours and sizes. **Pak Khlong Talat** is a surprisingly fun wholesale market for cut

### Tailoring tips

Bangkok is particularly well-known for its plethora of **tailoring shops**; here you can get a custom-made suit for amazingly low prices compared to the West. Choosing a tailor is tricky though. Tailors in the middle of tourist areas, such as Khao San Road or Nana Plaza, generally provide poor quality and often quote silly prices. Avoid any tailor recommended by touts or tuk-tuk drivers as they cannot be trusted and you'll have to pay their commission; also avoid super-cheap packages or anything done in 24 hr, as the quality will suffer accordingly. The most important rule for getting a good tailor: do research. Don't just walk in the first tailor shop you see, but ask fellow travellers and look online for (user) reviews. In general, the best tailors are slightly off the tourist track in Silom and Sukhumvit.

It will help considerably if you know fabrics and what style you want (bring along a sample or at least a picture), and can spare the time for at least three sessions for a suit (measurement, fitting and final adjustment). Prices obviously depend on the tailor's skill and the materials used, but expect to pay at least 7,000 baht for a two-piece suit. When picking the materials, you're best off with Italian or English cloth as

flowers and vegetables. If you're a morning person, visit it around 03:00, when new flowers from upcountry arrive and the marketplace is beautifully illuminated.

Thonburi, being one of the least developed areas of Bangkok, is the best place to experience what the city used to be like. A must is the weekends-only **Taling Chan Floating Market**, which feels at least somewhat authentic as it blends a rural market with the canal side way of life. **Wang Lang Market** is an undiscovered gem with strictly local prices. The other side of the river, Rattanakosin, has everything a good Buddhist would need, be it amulets, monk bowls or human-sized Buddha statues.

local fabrics are often of poor quality (with the exception of silk). Insist on two fittings for suits. Give the tailor a lot of detail and give yourself time, so you'll get the exact suit you're looking for.

For antiques, Silom is the place to go, as most potential buyers stay there in expensive hotels. **River City** in Yaowarat is the largest antique mall of the city, and priced to match. **Gold and gems are popular buys, but be careful:** know what you're looking for such as quality of workmanship and gold/stones and what something like it costs back home. If possible by prior research, not street vendor recommendation, go to respected jewellers, and polish your bargaining skills. Many tourists buy worthless pieces of cut glass believing it to be valuable gems. Others get jewellery or gems at unjustified costs. Never let tuk-tuk drivers take you to a gem/jewelry store; more often than not, you'll be ripped off and they're getting a commission for taking you there. The same advice applies to tailoring shops; you can get a custom-made suit at low prices, but you have to know where to go, as many tailors provide bad quality — see the sidebar for advice on finding a good tailor.

Browsing second hand English-language books can best be done on Khao San Road. For new releases, there are plenty of chain stores in shopping plazas, including **Asia Books**, **B2S**, **Bookazine** and **Kinokuniya**. There's a particularly wide array of books on Asian culture and history; some have a good selection of foreign newspapers and magazines as well.

## Eat

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*Individual listings can be found in Bangkok's district articles*

Bangkok boasts a stunning 50,000 places to eat; not only thousands of Thai restaurants, but a wide selection of world-class **international cuisine** too. With the rise of the expat community and high expenditure for local Thais, Bangkok has fast become a gastronomical paradise. Prices are generally high by Thai standards, but cheap by international standards. A good meal is unlikely to cost more than 300 baht, although there are a few restaurants (primarily in hotels) where you can easily spend 10 times this. Sukhumvit is known for many of popular restaurants but the business district of Silom is now littered with many of Bangkok's top dining destinations. Practically every cuisine in the world is represented here, be it French, Lebanese, Mexican, Vietnamese, or fusion combining many of these together in a quirky, but delicious mix. Bangkok's Italian town is **Soi Ton Son** near Siam Square. Of course, for those on a budget, street stalls abound with simple Thai dishes at around 30 baht. There are especially plenty of budget restaurants in Khao San Road.

There are plenty of **vegetarian restaurants** in the more tourist-friendly parts of town (especially in hippie district Khao San Road). Vegetarian dishes are also readily available on the menus of regular restaurants. On request, even typical street restaurants will easily cook a vegetarian equivalent of a popular Thai dish for you. Ask for "jay" food to leave the meat out of the dish. For example, "khao pad" is fried rice and "khao pad jay" is vegetarian fried rice. The most common animal product used would be oyster sauce. To avoid it, say "mai ao naam man hoi". Be aware that all street noodle vendors use meat broth for noodle soup.



Pad Thai



For Muslims, the alleys around Haroon Mosque in the Bang Rak area are home to many Muslim families, and hence full of stalls selling **halal** food. Another good place to find halal food is the Ramkhamhaeng Night Market, located next to the campus of Ramkhamhaeng University.

Don't miss out on a cold **ice cream** in hot Bangkok. Western chain stores **Dairy Queen** and **Swensen's** have booths in many malls and shopping centres. Or better yet, try an exotic fruit-flavoured ice cream at an **Iberry** shop. Their ice creams are tasty, cheap and safe to eat. Korean-style **shaved ice** has become very popular, and local chain **After You (<https://www.afteryoudessertcafe.com/en/>)** has many branches in Bangkok, and is a very popular hangout spot among Thai youths and young adults.

If you need a late-night snack or basic supplies, look for a convenience store. They are open around the clock and accept cash or card.

## Street food

While generally not particularly high class, street food is among the most delicious food and there even is a venue that earned a Michelin star in their 2018 guide. The venues can be found all over Bangkok—wherever you're staying, you rarely have to walk more than 100 m for a cart or street restaurant. Many street vendors sell **satay** (สะเต๊ะ) with hot sauce for 5-10 baht a piece.

One of Thailand's national dishes you can try is **pad thai** (ผัดไทย), stir-fried rice noodles with eggs, fish sauce, tamarind juice and red chili pepper. It can be prepared for you on one of the ubiquitous carts or served in a street restaurant for about 50 baht. You can order it with chicken (*kai*) or shrimps (*kung*). Another one of Thailand's national dishes you should try is **tom yam kung** (ต้มยำกุ้ง), a sour soup with prawns, lemongrass and galangal—beware, as it is *very* spicy! **Khao man kai** (ข้าวมันไก่) is another popular street food. You can identify it at stalls displaying boiled chicken. Served with a bowl of fragrant chicken soup is a mound of rice topped with sliced chicken pieces and cucumber. Side sauces are spicy and go well with the bland chicken and rice. You can sometimes add optional liver and gizzard if that is your taste. If you like sweets, try to find a **kanom roti** (โรตีส) street vendor. The crepe-like dessert is filled with sweetened condensed milk, lots of sugar and can also have bananas inside. Also fun to watch them being made.



Khao San Road is known for its carts selling **bugs**—yes, insects. They are deep fried, nutritious and quite tasty with the soy sauce that is sprayed on them. Types available: scorpions, water beetles, grasshoppers, crickets, bamboo larvae, mealworms and some seasonal specialties. Break off the legs from grasshoppers and crickets or they will get stuck in your throat.



Insects—ready for a snack?



Around the corner from Khao San Road in front of the department store and supermarkets the street is lined with a myriad stalls selling all manner of tempting delicacies: sweets and crackers, coconut jellies, candied fruits, fish balls on skewers, tamarind sweets dipped in chili and sugar and a host of other delights.

## Ethnic cuisine

*Main article: Thai cuisine*

Thai dishes can roughly be categorised into central, northern, northeastern and southern cuisine. What's so great about Bangkok is that all these cuisines are present. **Isaan food** (from the northeast of Thailand) is popular; generally street restaurants serve on plenty of small plates that can be shared. **Som tam** (ส้มตำ) is a salad made from shredded and pounded raw papaya — again, it is *spicy*, but oh so delicious. If you want to dine the Isaan way, also order some **khao niew** (sticky rice), **kai yang** (grilled chicken) and **moo yang** (grilled pork). Isaan food is very spicy; say *mai pet* or *pet nit noi* to tone it down. Southern Thai cuisine is also worth it; many of them have congregated around Wang Lang in Thonburi. At least try the **massaman curry** (แกงมัสมั่น), it's delicious.

One of the best places to go to for **Chinese food** is Yaowarat. It has a range of street stalls and cheap restaurants selling expensive delicacies at affordable prices. **Soi Phadung Dao** is the best street for huge seafood restaurants. Try 1 kg of huge barbecued prawns for about 300 baht. That being said, due to the large Thai-Chinese population in Bangkok, Chinese influences pervade much of Bangkok's culinary scene, and even outside Chinatown, many of Bangkok's most famous street food stalls are owned by ethnic Chinese. As most of Yaowarat's residents are local-born Thai-Chinese who have been in Thailand for multiple generations, the food there has been significantly localised and differs noticeably from the original versions of the dishes you will find in China. For more authentic Chinese cuisine that is closer to what is served in China, go to Pracha Rat Bamphen in Hwai Khwang, which is home to a large number of immigrants and expatriates from China, and a large number of Chinese restaurants serving various regional Chinese cuisines to cater to that crowd.

Phahurat, Bangkok's Little India, has some decent Indian restaurants.

## Fine dining

Bangkok is arguably the best city in Southeast Asia for fine dining, and there is no shortage of options for those who can afford to splurge the cash. Fine dining options in Bangkok include French, Italian, Chinese, Indian, Japanese and, of course, Thai. Although exorbitant by Thai

standards, fine dining in Bangkok is very affordable compared to similar options in developed countries, and even the most expensive fine dining should not cost you more than 5000 baht per head.

## Dinner cruises

Dinner cruises on the Chao Phraya River are a touristy (but fun) way of spotting floodlit temples while chowing down on seafood and watching Thai cultural performances. Most operate buffet-style and the quality of the food is so-so, but there's lots of it and it's not too spicy. While the river can give a romantic experience, it can also be dirty and smelly with lots of plants floating around.

Drinks and tips are usually *not* included in the listed prices below. Always make a reservation before heading out to the pier. There are many competing operators, most of them depart from the **River City** pier next to the **Si Phraya** Express Boat pier. Major operators include:

- **Chao Phraya Princess** (<http://www.thaicruise.com/>), 723 Supakarn Building, Charoen Nakhorn Rd, ☎ +66 2 860-3700. Departure 19:30. Large operator with four modern air-conditioned boats seating up to 250 people. Departure from River City pier. 1,300 baht.
- **Loy Nava** (<http://www.loynava.com>), 1367 Charoen Nakhorn Rd, ☎ +66 2 437-4932. Departure 18:00 or 20:10 daily. This dinner cruise heads out with 70-seater rice barges. Departure from Si Phraya pier (near River City), and there is a free pickup from most hotels. 1,400 baht.
- **Manohra** (<http://www.manohracruises.com/>), 257 Charoen Nakhorn Rd, ☎ +66 2 477-0770. Departure 19:30 daily. These restored Thai rice barges seat 40 people. Departure from Marriott Resort pier, with an optional pick-up from Saphan Taksin BTS station. 1,250-1,990 baht.
- **Wan Fah** (<https://wanfah.in.th/>), 292 Rachawongse Rd, ☎ +66 2 222-8679. Departure 19:00 daily. These 2-hr dinner cruises include a set meal of farang-friendly Thai food and seafood, live music and Thai classical dancing. Departure from River City. 1,000 baht.
- **Yok Yor Marina** (<https://www.yokyor.co.th/>), 885 Somdet Chao Phraya Soi 17, ☎ +66 2 863-0565. Departure 20:00. Operated by the famous seafood restaurant, this is a much more local (and cheaper) option than the tourist cruises: pay a 160 baht "boat fee" and then order off the menu at normal restaurant prices. Departure from Yok Yor Marina on the Thonburi side of the river. There is a free shuttle service from Saphan Taksin BTS station.

## Drink

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*Individual listings can be found in Bangkok's district articles*

Bangkok's nightlife is **infamously wild**, but it's not quite what it used to be. Due to social order campaigns, there have been quite a few crack-downs on opening hours, nudity, and drug use. Most restaurants, bars and clubs are now forced to close at 01:00, although quite a few are allowed to stay open till 02:00 or later. Informal roadside bars do stay open all night, particularly in Sukhumvit and Khao San Road. You must carry your **passport** for ID checks and police occasionally raid bars and discos, subjecting all customers to **drug tests** and searches, though these mostly occur at places that cater for high-society Thais.

One of Bangkok's main party districts is Silom, home to a wide range of bars and nightclubs catering to all tastes, as well as the famous Patpong night market area. For a drink with a view, the open-air rooftop bars of Vertigo and Sirocco are particularly impressive. A large number of stylish and upscale bars and nightclubs can be found in the higher sois of Sukhumvit, particularly the hip area of Thong Lo (Soi 55).

Hippie hangout Khao San Road is also slowly gentrifying and a score of young artsy Thai teenagers have also made their mark there. Going out in Khao San Road is mostly casual, sitting at a roadside bar watching people pass by, but the **Gazebo Club** is a nightclub that stays open till the sun gets up. Most of the younger Thais prefer to congregate around Ratchadaphisek, home to the **Royal City Avenue** strip of nightclubs where you can find popular nightclubs like 808, Route 66, Cosmic Cafe, and more.



Sirocco at State Tower, Silom



RCA, the **Royal City Avenue** strip, is home to much more than nightclubs. You will be able to find fun karaoke clubs, go-carting, arcades and bars like the Overtone Music Cave which is a place where music students to perform. The Overtone Music Cave is frequently visited by recording artists as well as music students and is becoming a real Bangkok music hot spot.

Smoking is forbidden in all restaurants, bars and nightclubs, whether air-conditioned or non-air-conditioned. It is enforced at some venues, but the ordinance is flouted in areas such as Nana Plaza.

## Gay nightlife

Thais are generally accepting of homosexuality and Bangkok has a very active gay nightlife scene, concentrated in Silom's Soi 2, Soi 4 and a short strip of gay go-go bars known as **Soi Twilight** (off Surawong Road). Gay strip bars all have free entry, but charge an extra 150 baht or so for drinks. The most popular gay drinking bars are **The Balcony** and **Telephone Pub** at Silom Soi 4, which are busy until 23:00. For the disco crowd, **DJ Station** and its late-night neighbour **G.O.D. Club** (Silom Soi 2) are packed every night beginning around 23:00. Between 17:00-22:00 over 200 men from around the world cruise, swim, dine, and party at the nearby **Babylon**, considered by many to be the best gay sauna in the world. Babylon also has budget and luxury accommodation.

All of these bars and clubs are aimed at gay men and the lesbian scene is much more low-key. Since the opening of full-time lesbian bars **Zeta** and **E-Fun**, a small lesbian community is starting to emerge along Royal City Avenue. **Lesla** (near Phahonyothin) is a lesbian bar that is open on Saturday nights only. Bring along your passport for entrance age checking (they do not allow people under 20 years old).

In a league of their own are Bangkok's numerous **transsexuals** (*kathoei*), both pre- and post-operative, popularly known as **ladyboys**. A part of Thai popular culture for ages, kathoei face increasing prejudice as Thailand imports rigid Western gender concepts. Many male Westerners obsess about the risks of "mistaking" a ladyboy for a "real" woman, in the fear that being

attracted to them would make of them homosexuals. Tired clichés about "tall, large-handed, large breasted transsexuals with garish makeup" are belied by the fact that most kathoeyes strive to blend in with the general population. However, legal change of gender is not possible in Thailand, which means they find it difficult to access many "respectable" jobs. Some work in the famed **transvestite cabarets** and there are some dedicated *kathoey* bars as well.

## Sleep

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*Individual listings can be found in Bangkok's district articles*

Bangkok has a vast range of accommodation, including some of the best hotels in the world — but also some of the worst dives. Broadly speaking, Khao San Road is backpacker city; the riverside of Silom and Thonburi is home to **The Oriental** and **The Peninsula** respectively, often ranked among the best in the world, and priced to match. Most of the city's moderate and expensive hotels can be found in Siam Square, Sukhumvit and Silom, though they also have their share of budget options.

When choosing your digs, think of the amount of luxury you want to pay for — air-conditioning can be advised, as temperatures don't drop below 20 °C (68 °F) at night. Also pay careful attention to Skytrain, metro and express boat access, as a well-placed station or pier could make your stay in Bangkok much more comfortable. In general, accommodation in Bangkok is cheap. It's possible to have a decent double room with hot shower and air-conditioning for about 500 baht/night. If you want more luxury, expect to pay around 1,500 baht for a double room in the main tourist areas. Even staying at one of Bangkok's top hotels only costs around 5,000 baht — the price of a standard double room in much of Europe.

Some Bangkok hotels charge a **guest fee** of around 500 baht if you bring a visitor back for the night, and some hotels in Khao San Road refuse Thai guests altogether. Hotel security may hold onto your guest's ID card for the duration of the visit. These policies can sometimes be applied to Western visitors or to your Thai partner, which can be awkward. Look for signs at the front desk, or ask staff before check-in if in doubt.

### Book online, save money

While most guest houses in Khao San Road do not even bother to have a website, with moderate and upper end hotels you can save a surprisingly large amount of money by booking via the web. In most cases, walk-in rates are known to be about 30% higher than online rates as administration costs are higher and front desk personnel often get paid by commission. When standing inside the hotel's lobby, sometimes it can pay off to use the free Wi-Fi, get online, book for the same night and get it for less! To give an example, some mid-range hotels offer walk-in rates for 1,500 baht the night, but online rates for 1,000 baht. That's five free beers on the hotel! Nevertheless, don't take that as a general rule for Thailand. On some island resorts it's exactly the other way round, and the walk-in rates are only half of the online promoted price, especially in offseason.



## Stay safe

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Given its size, Bangkok is surprisingly safe, with violent crimes like mugging and robbery unusual. Most violent crime in Bangkok is connected to disputes between organized crime syndicates; if you do not bother them, they generally will not bother you. Generally speaking, the tourists who get into trouble are the ones who get into drunken fights. One of the biggest dangers are motorbikes who ride on pavements at speed, go through red lights, undertake buses as they stop to let passengers off and generally drive far too fast especially through stationary traffic. If you are going to hire a bike, make sure you have insurance in case you are injured. You may be the world's best driver but you'll meet many of the world's worst drivers in Thailand.

Bangkok does have more than its fair share of **scams**, and many individuals in the tourist business do not hesitate to **overcharge** unwary visitors. As a rule of thumb, it is wise to decline all offers made by someone who appears to be a friendly local giving a hapless tourist some local advice. Short-changing tourists is reasonably common as well, don't hesitate to complain if you are not given the correct change.

Never get in a tuk-tuk if someone else is trying to get you into one. Most Bangkok locals do not approach foreigners without an ulterior motive.

Possession and use of e-cigarettes (vapes) are illegal here. Violators can face heavy fines or even imprisonment.

### Scams

There are dozens of scams in Bangkok, but by far the most widely practiced is the **gem scam**. Always beware of tuk-tuk drivers offering **all-day tours for prices as low as 10 baht**. You may indeed be taken on a full-day tour, but you will end up only visiting one gem and souvenir shop after another. Don't buy any products offered by pushy salespeople — the "gems" you can supposedly sell overseas for huge profits are pretty much always worthless pieces of cut glass and the suits are of deplorable quality. The tuk-tuk driver gets a commission if you buy something — and fuel coupons even if you don't. Unless the idea of travelling by tuk-tuk appeals to you, it's almost always cheaper, more comfortable and less hassle to take a metered taxi.

Be highly skeptical when an English-speaking Thai at a popular tourist attraction approaches you **out of the blue**, telling that your intended destination is **closed** or offering discount admissions. Temples are almost always free (the main exceptions are Wat Phra Kaeo and Wat Pho) and open just about every day of the year. Anyone telling you otherwise, even if they have an

#### What to do if you fall for the gem scam

As long as you're still in Thailand, it's not too late. Contact the **Tourist Authority of Thailand**, ☎ [+66 2 694-1222](tel:+6626941222) or the **Tourist Police**, ☎ 1155 immediately, file a police report, and return to the store to claim a refund — they **must**, by law, return 80%. If your gems have been mailed, contact the **Bangkok Mail Centre**, ☎ [+66 2 215-0966](tel:+6622150966) (-195) immediately and ask them to track your package; they'll find it if you act fast, and know the name, address and date it was mailed.



official-looking identification card, is most likely out to scam you, especially if they suggest a tuk-tuk ride to some alternate sights to see until the sight re-opens. At paid admission sites, verify the operating hours at the ticket window.

If you entered one of these tuk-tuks, touts will often drop you off at a certain place, such as a genuine Buddhist temple. Here you will find a man that claims to be an official, and he guides you in a certain direction. There you will find another "official" who also claims that a certain attraction is closed. This way, a tourist hears the same statement by multiple people, and is more eager to believe that his or her intended destination indeed is closed. Never get involved with these scammers or believe any of their statements.

When getting a taxi, it is a good idea to **hail a moving taxi** from the main road, walk a short distance out of a major tourist area before looking for one, or use a ride-hailing app. This is no guarantee of honesty, but greatly increases your chances of finding an honest driver, of which there are plenty in Bangkok, even if it sometimes seems that every driver is on the make. There are some taxi drivers who switch off their meters, and insist on an unreasonable price. Most of the untrustworthy drivers are the ones standing still in tourist areas. Another important rule of thumb is to **insist on the meter** for taxis and **agree on a price in advance** for tuk-tuks. If they refuse, or quote unreasonable prices, just walk out and get a different one as they're rarely in short supply. The Thai phrase to ask a driver to use the meter is *mee-TOE, khap* if you're male and *mee-TOE, kha* if you're female. Don't ask taxi drivers for recommendations, they'll take you to the place that pays the highest commission.

Also beware of **private bus companies** offering direct trips from Bangkok to other cities with "VIP" buses. There are a lot of scams performed by these private bus companies. The so-called direct VIP trips may end up changing three or four uncomfortable minibuses to the destination, and the 10-11-hour trip may well turn into 17-18 hr. Instead, try to book public Transport Co. buses from the main bus terminals. It's worth the extra shoe-leather, as there have been reports of robberies on private buses as well.

## Go-go bars

Bangkok has a well-known nightlife scene, and some aspects of the sex industry are illegal (soliciting, pimping), though enforcement is inconsistent.

Thailand has a high rate of STI infection including HIV/AIDS, particularly among nightlife industry workers. Exercise caution and be aware that drink spiking has been reported in some establishments.



Tuk-tuks in Bangkok



While walking in go-go bar areas is generally safe, be cautious of touts who try to draw you into upstairs bars with offers of ping-pong shows and cheap beer. The beer price may be as advertised, but the "show" will typically cost 1,000 baht or more. As a rule, if you cannot see inside from street level, avoid the establishment.

## Animal abuse

Elephants are a large part of Thailand's tourist business, and the smuggling and mistreatment of elephants for tourist attractions is a widespread practice. Be aware that elephants are often separated from their mothers at a young age to be cruelly trained under captivity for the rest of their lives. Animal charities advise that elephant-friendly tourists should **avoid visiting venues offering elephant rides**.

A depressingly common sight on the congested streets of Bangkok is **elephant begging**. During night hours, mahouts (trainers) with lumbering elephants approach tourists to feed the creatures bananas or take a photo with them for a fee. The elephants are brought to the city to beg in this way because they are out of work and are mistreated and visibly distressed under the conditions of the city. Please avoid supporting this cruelty by rejecting the mahouts as they offer you bananas to feed the elephants. This is especially common in Silom and Sukhumvit.

Due to its location, lax laws, and resources, many **illegal animal products** come through Bangkok. Rare and endangered species are often sold at markets for pets, especially at Chatuchak, and many other animal products are sold as luxury items. Avoid buying rare pets, leather, ivory, talons, dried sea creatures (such as starfish), fur, feathers, teeth, wool, and other products since they are most likely the result of illegal poaching, and buying them contributes greatly to animal endangerment and abuse. You could also be arrested and charged under your country's law for trafficking endangered species.

## Political unrest

Thai politics are a rough sport and when tensions boil over, protests in Bangkok inevitably ensue and can turn violent. While tourists are rarely if ever targeted, in 2008 one faction managed to close down both of Bangkok's airports for a week, wrecking many travel plans.

The latest round of tension kicked off in 2020 when the reformist Future Forward Party was banned, sparking mass protests by young protesters opposed to the military junta and, even more controversially, the Thai monarchy itself. Hundreds were arrested and many charged with crimes including sedition and *lèse-majesté*, with one protester handed a sentence of 87 years in jail. While the COVID situation put a damper on the protests, the underlying tensions are far from resolved. Follow the independent press for the newest political developments and stay away from demonstrations.



Barricades in central Bangkok during the redshirt protests in 2010

## Food and water

As elsewhere in Thailand, be careful with what you eat. Outside of major tourist hotels and resorts, stay away from raw leafy vegetables, egg-based dressings like mayonnaise, unpackaged ice cream and minced meat as hot weather tends to make food go bad faster. In short, stick to boiled, baked, fried or peeled food.

Tap water in Bangkok is said to be safe when it comes out the plant, but unfortunately the plumbing along the way often is not, so do not drink it. Any water served to you in good restaurants will at least be boiled, but it's best to stick to bottled water, which is ubiquitous and cheap.

Take care with ice, which may be made with tap water of questionable potability as above. The ice with round holes is made by commercial ice makers who purify their water. However, restaurants or stalls which buy a big block of ice and chip bits off of it for your drink may be suspect. While the big ice blocks are also commercially made from purified water, the staff may not be handling it hygienically.

The cheapest way to get drinking water is from streetside reverse osmosis water vending machines. You can fill your own bottles for only a few baht.

## Stay healthy

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### Medical care

Many people go to Bangkok to undergo medical treatments that are a fraction of the cost charged in their home countries. While public hospitals can be understaffed and overcrowded with long wait times, private hospitals are among the best in the world. The best-regarded, and most expensive (though still affordable by Western standards), is **Bumrungrad International Hospital** (<http://www.bumrungrad.com/>), which attracts about 400,000 foreign patients per year or an average of 1,000+ a day. There are also other hospitals, such as **Samitivej** (<http://www.samitivejhospitals.com/>), **Bangkok Hospital** (<https://www.bangkokhospital.com/>) and **BNH Hospital** (<https://www.bnhhospital.com/>), that specialize in serving foreigners. Private hospitals in Thailand are accredited by the government according to international standards, and many of the doctors in Thailand hold international accreditation and relevant licences. Staff in private hospitals are generally able to speak English well, and sometimes other foreign languages as well.

Popular treatments, ranging from cosmetic, organ transplants and orthopedic treatments to dental and cardiac surgeries, are available much cheaper than in the West. For example, Bumrungrad Hospital charges 90,000 baht for an all-inclusive breast implant package. Bangkok is also known as a centre for **sexual reassignment surgery** for people wishing to change their physical sex, although this falls out of the scope of a casual trip.

There are many dental clinics with English-speaking dentists and staff. The largest of them is the **Bangkok International Dental Center** (<http://www.bangkokdentalcenter.com/>) along Ratchadaphisek Road. There are also plenty of well known teeth whitening, implant and orthodontic providers, easily researchable online.

# Connect

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## Cellphone

Prepaid SIM cards for tourists are readily available at the airport arrivals hall and convenience stores. They offer generous data packages at low rates.

## Internet

Due to the surge of mobile connectivity, Internet cafés are not common as they used to be. If you look carefully, you may find them in tourist districts such as Khao San Road for around 30-60 baht per hour.

Many cafés and pubs do offer free Wi-Fi to their customers, including the ubiquitous **Coffee World** chain in all of its branches; ask staff for the password. **TrueMove** offers both free and paid Wi-Fi access. If you want to get online for free, you must register first, and both session and time is limited. Their network is accessible in many malls, including Siam Square, and sometimes can be available from your room if you stay in a nearby hot-spot — just look for the 'truewifi' network, you can register. Most hotels and guest houses provide free Wi-Fi.

There is not a lot of free Wi-Fi available in old districts like Rattanakosin or Yaowarat. Even at McDonald's and Starbucks, Wi-Fi is not free or not available at all.

If you are staying for more than a couple of days and prefer to stay connected without being limited to hotspots, a prepaid SIM card with mobile data is a good option. Being able to use a smartphone for navigation and reviews is very useful in a city where recommendations and directions offered by locals are not always reliable. See the Telephone section for details.

## Telephone

The area code for Bangkok is **02**. You only need to dial the 0 if you're calling from within Thailand. Pay phones are not commonplace, as most Thais have a mobile phone. If you want to avoid high roaming costs, you can buy a local SIM card for 100 baht at Suvarnabhumi Airport or mobile phone shops throughout the city. The 100 baht is not just for the SIM card, but is immediately your first pre-paid amount. Topping it up is easy, such as at 7-Eleven convenience stores. Making international calls is also cheaper this way.

As of July 2014, the True booth at Suvarnabhumi Airport is offering free tourist Sim cards preloaded with 10 baht calling credit as well as 20 MB of 3G access.

## Post

Bangkok's red post boxes are found all over the city. There are also plenty of **Thailand Post** (<http://www.thailandpost.com/>) offices around for sending post and packages. In tourist areas, there are post offices in the Khao San Road area (in front of Wat Bowonniwet) and at Sukhumvit Road (between Soi 4 and 6).



If you're staying in Bangkok for a longer time, you might want to make use of *poste restante*, so other people can send you letters or parcels using a post office's address. Post offices keep the letters for at least two months. Letters sent via *poste restante* must have the receiver's name on it, with the family name in underlined capital letters. If you want to pick them up near Khao San Road (opposite Wat Bowonniwet), it must be addressed to Poste Restante, Banglamphubon Post Office, Bangkok, 10203, Thailand. If you want to pick up your post in the Sukhumvit area, address it to Poste Restante, Nana Post Office, Sukhumvit Road, Bangkok, 10112, Thailand.



A Thailand Post mailbox



## Cope

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### Publications

- **Bangkok Post** (<http://bangkokpost.com/>). One of the better English-language newspapers of the country, but also includes sections on travel, leisure, entertainment, life and classifieds in Bangkok.
- **BK Magazine** (<http://bk.asia-city.com/>). Bangkok's premier city living magazine; a guide to the city's restaurants, nightlife, travel, arts and more. New additions release weekly and are distributed in selected venues.
- **Sukhumvit Guide** (<http://www.sukhumvitguide.com/>). A complete listing guide to the hotels, restaurants and bars of Sukhumvit, one of Bangkok's most vibrant districts.

### Immigration office

- **1 Immigration Bureau** ([https://bangkok.immigration.go.th/en/home\\_en/](https://bangkok.immigration.go.th/en/home_en/)), Government Bldg B, Chaeng Wattana Soi 7, ☎ +66 2 141-9889. M-F 08:30-noon, 13:00-16:30. Visas, re-entry permits and many other immigration services are available. The Visa On Arrival can be extended on a simple procedure. The modern big Government Building in Lak Si host the Immigration Division. Official name? "Government Complex Commemorating His Majesty The King's Eighty Birthday Anniversary, 5 December, BE 2550 (2007)" But let's just call it: "Chaeng Watthana Government Complex" Bus 66 and 166 enter the compounds and stop at the main door (Gate 1) It's a two Km from Lak Si train station (northern and northeaster line) which is the next one after Don Mueang Airport. The Immigration Bureau is on the big B building, it's next to the gate 2 (the southern one)

They will request a passport picture (facilities there, 4 pics for 100 baht) and copy of your passport (including the page where the stamp is) 4 baht per both copies. After filling the form a number will be given. If you're not an early bird, the lunch break will catch you, and you will need to wait for that hour, when everybody goes to eat on the big food courts (from 13:00 to 14:00) Supermarkets available. With the number given, and 1900 baht the new stamp will be added to your passport, with extra 30 days after the days your visa finish. The building also host many other offices, like the Consumer Protection Board, Election Commission, the Office of Justice Affairs, among many others. Worth the forced visit. Services for Burmese, Cambodian and Lao citizens remain at the central old location at Soi Suan Plu.

## Embassies

Diplomatic missions[\[Expand\]](#)

## Go next

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### Central Thailand

If you want to get out of the city for a while, there are plenty of day trip options from Bangkok.

- [Amphawa](#) — interesting floating market popular with the locals
- [Ayutthaya](#) — ancient capital showcasing its many ruins, 1.5 hr away by bus or train
- [Bang Pa-In](#) — its magnificent Summer Palace makes for a pleasant day trip
- [Damnoen Saduak](#) — picture-perfect floating market on tourist steroids
- [Hua Hin](#) — beach resort town with nearby waterfalls and national parks
- [Kanchanaburi](#) — the famous Bridge over the River Kwai, the Erawan Falls and Hellfire Pass
- [Ko Kret](#) — rustic island to the north of Bangkok renowned for pottery making, a pleasant day trip out of the concrete jungle
- [Nakhon Pathom](#) — Thailand's oldest city and site of the world's largest stupa
- [Phetchaburi](#) — relaxed historic town with the Khao Wang mountain, colourful temples and delicious desserts

### Further destinations

Bangkok is also an excellent hub for onward travel into other regions of [Thailand](#).

- [Chiang Mai](#) — the gateway to the north and the heart of Lanna culture
- [Khao Yai National Park](#) — stunning mountainous scenery and some of Thailand's fledgling vineyards
- [Ko Chang](#) — large relatively unspoiled tropical island
- [Ko Samet](#) — the closest beach island to Bangkok with white sand beaches
- [Krabi Province](#) — the beautiful beaches and islands of Ao Nang, Rai Leh, Ko Phi Phi and Ko Lanta
- [Nakhon Ratchasima](#) (*Khorat*) — main city in the Isaan region
- [Phuket](#) — the original Thai paradise island, now very developed but still with some beautiful beaches
- [Sukhothai](#) — the ruins of the ancient Sukhothai Kingdom
- [Surat Thani](#) — gateway to [Ko Samui](#), [Ko Pha Ngan](#) and [Ko Tao](#)

If you are considering leaving Thailand there are overland routes to the following destinations:

- [Siem Reap](#) — near the [Angkor temples](#).
- [Phnom Penh](#) — capital of [Cambodia](#)
- [Vientiane](#) — capital of [Laos](#)
- [Ho Chi Minh City](#) — largest city in [Vietnam](#), another foodie's paradise, some distance away but often the end point of a journey that includes Siem Reap and Phnom Penh in Cambodia; see [Bangkok to Ho Chi Minh City overland](#).

**Routes through Bangkok**

|                                                     |         |                                                                                                           |     |                                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|---------------------------------------------|
|                                                     | END ← W |  <b>SRT Eastern Line</b>  | E → | Chachoengsao → <b>Aranyaprathet</b>         |
|                                                     | END ← N |  <b>SRT Eastern Line</b> | S → | Chonburi → <b>Pattaya</b>                   |
| <b>Vientiane (Thanaleng), Nong Khai</b> ← Ayutthaya | ← N     |                          | S → | END                                         |
|                                                     | END ← W |                          | E → | Nakhon Ratchasima → <b>Ubon Ratchathani</b> |
| <b>Chiang Mai</b> ← Rangsit                         | ← N     |                          | S → | END                                         |
|                                                     | END ← N |                          | S → | Nakhon Pathom → <b>Butterworth</b>          |
| <b>Kanchanaburi</b> ← Nakhon Pathom                 | ← W     |                          | E → | END                                         |
| <b>Samut Songkhram</b> ← Samut Sakhon               | ← W     |                          | E → | END                                         |

#### Routes through Bangkok

|                             |         |                                                                                            |     |                                |
|-----------------------------|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|--------------------------------|
| <b>Chiang Rai</b> ← Rangsit | ← N     |  <b>1</b> | S → | END                            |
| <b>Nong Khai</b> ← Saraburi | ← N     |  <b>2</b> | S → | Rangsit → <b>END</b>           |
|                             | END ← W |  <b>3</b> | E → | Samut Prakan → <b>Trat</b>     |
|                             | END ← N |  <b>4</b> | S → | Nakhon Pathom → <b>Hat Yai</b> |

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